

Valence Asymmetry seminar
December 2, 2025



Why miratives are (un)expected

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Universitat
Pompeu Fabra
Barcelona

In a nutshell

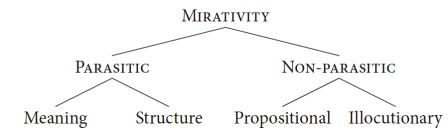


2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German

In a nutshell



2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German



Why miratives are unexpected

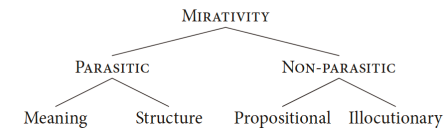
In a nutshell



2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German



Why miratives are expected (Part 1 The view from the interactional spine)



Why miratives are unexpected

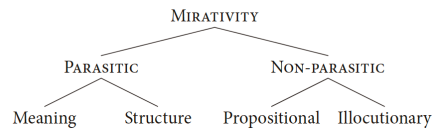
In a nutshell



2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German



Why miratives are expected (Part 1 The view from the interactional spine)



Why miratives are unexpected

	Pro Ground _{pr}	Pro Ground _{pr}	Ground _{pr} [+coin]	Ground _{pr} [+coin]	Ground _{pr} [+coin]	Ground _{pr} [+coin]
UAG	ma	geh	leicht	huit	owa	doch
Burgenland	ma	geh	leicht	huit	owa	
Bavarian	ach	beh	leicht	huit	owa	
Swabian	ach	beh	leicht	huit	owa	
Norddeutsch	oh	aber	leicht	huit	owa	
Standard	ach	aber	leicht	huit	owa	
	na sowas	aber	etwa	echt	aber	
	vow		tatsächlich			
	boah					
	ey					

Strategies in other German varieties

In a nutshell

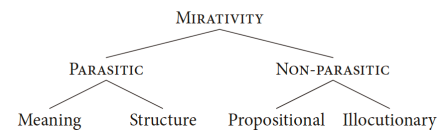


2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German



Why miratives are expected (Part 1 The view from the interactional spine)

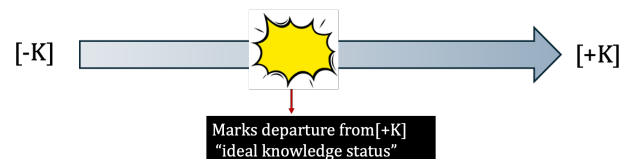
Why miratives are expected (Part 2 The view from the grammar of knowledge)



Why miratives are unexpected

	Pro Ground _{mir}	Pro Ground _{mir}	Ground _{mir} [+coin]	Ground _{mir} [+coin]	Ground _{mir} [+coin]	Ground _{mir} [+coin]
UAG	ma	geh	leicht	huit	owa	
Burgenland	ma		hiescht			
	boah		eppa			
Bavarian					fei	
Swabian	ach				oba	
		beh				doch
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Standard	ach		etwa		aber	
	na sowas		echt			
	vow	aber	tatsächlich			
	boah					
	ey					

Strategies in other German varieties





2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German



2 mirative strategies in UAG

Context 1

Xaver sees his friend drawing a beautiful picture.
He is surprised that his friend can draw.



2 mirative strategies in UAG



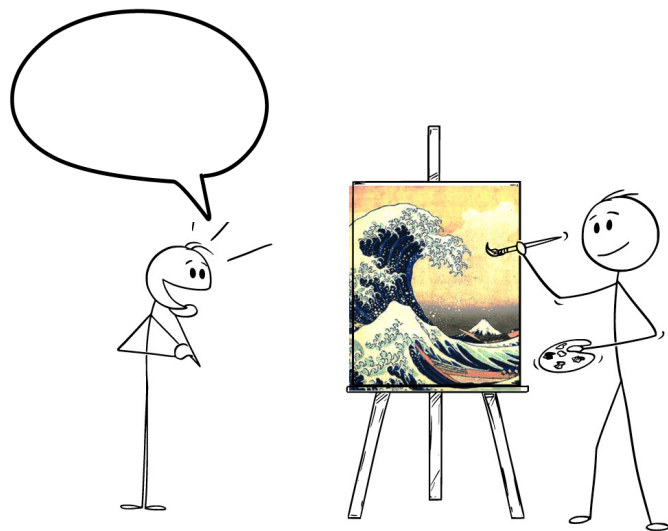
“interjection”

Ma wos moch-st’n du do schens?

MA what make-2SG-PRT 2SG there beautiful

‘What beautiful thing are you making?’

2 mirative strategies in UAG



“interjection”

Ma wos moch-st’n du do schens?

MA what make-2SG-PRT 2SG there beautiful

‘What beautiful thing are you making?’

“discourse particle”

Du konn-st **leicht** zeichnen?

2SG can-2SG LEICHT draw

‘You can draw?’

2 mirative strategies in UAG

Are these really miratives?



“interjection”

Ma wos moch-st’n du do schens?

MA what make-2SG-PRT 2SG there beautiful

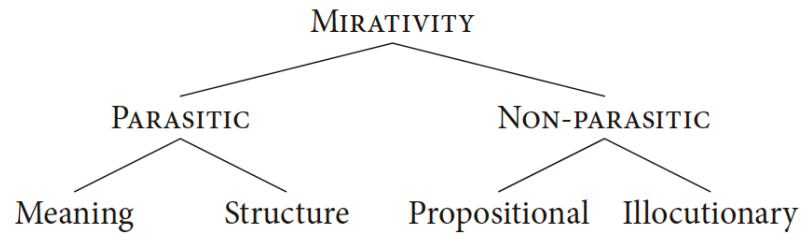
‘What beautiful thing are you making?’

“discourse particle”

Du konn-st **leicht** zeichnen?

2SG can-2SG LEICHT draw

‘You can draw?’



Why miratives are **unexpected**

What (some) other people have said

Why miratives are **unexpected**

Meaning

- (i) sudden discovery, sudden revelation or realization
- (ii) surprise
- (iii) unprepared mind
- (iv) counterexpectation
- (v) new information

(Aikhenvald, 2012)

Why miratives are **unexpected**

Form-Meaning

We use the term ‘mirative’
as a label for any natural-language expression of exceeded expectation

(Rett & Sturman, 2022)

Why miratives are **unexpected**

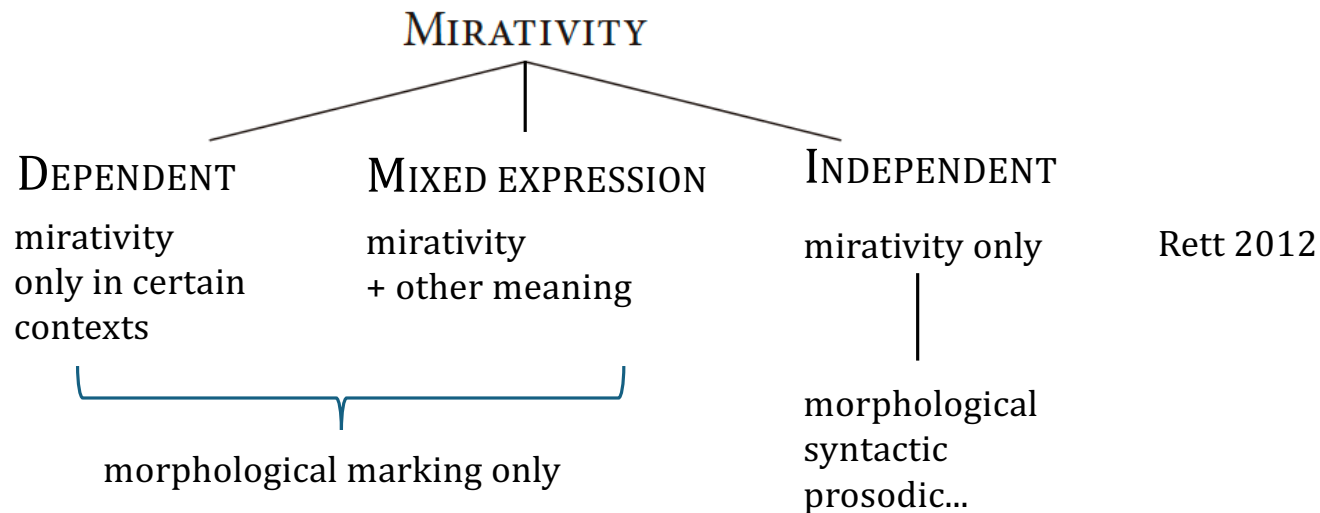
Form

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Why miratives are **unexpected**

Form

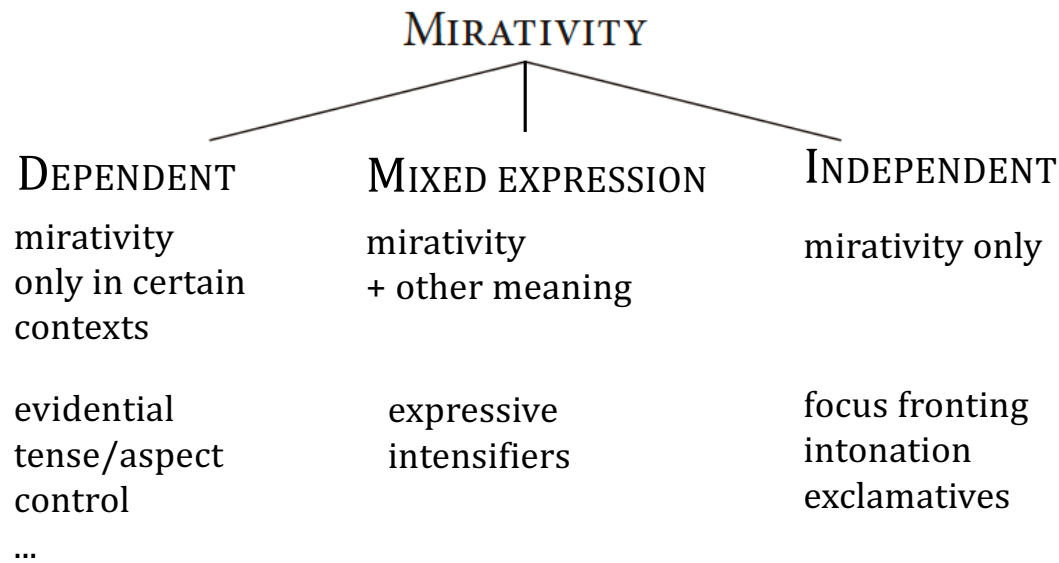
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Why miratives are **unexpected**

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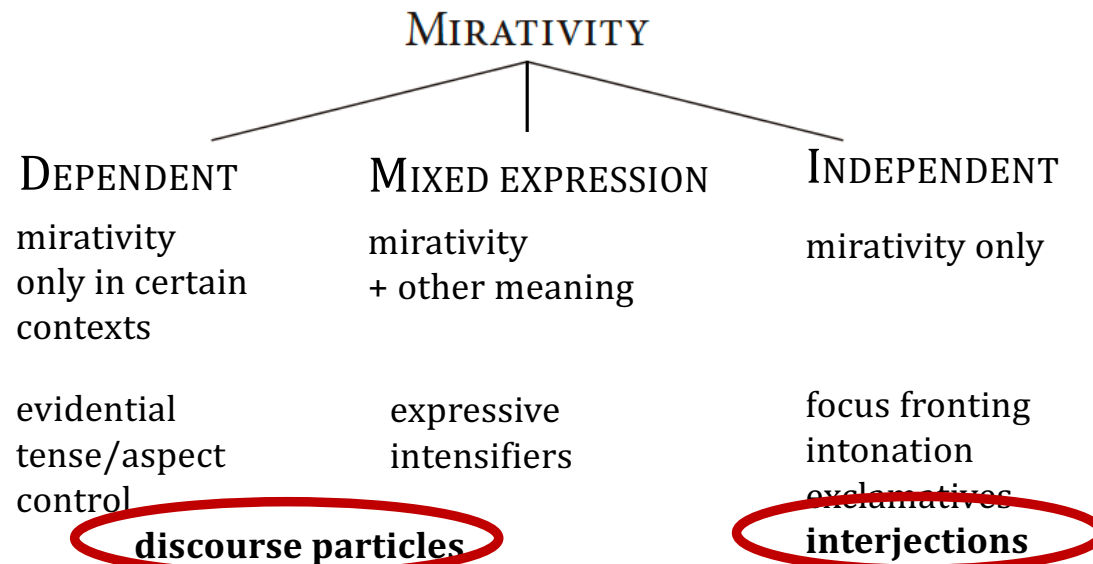
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Why miratives are **unexpected**

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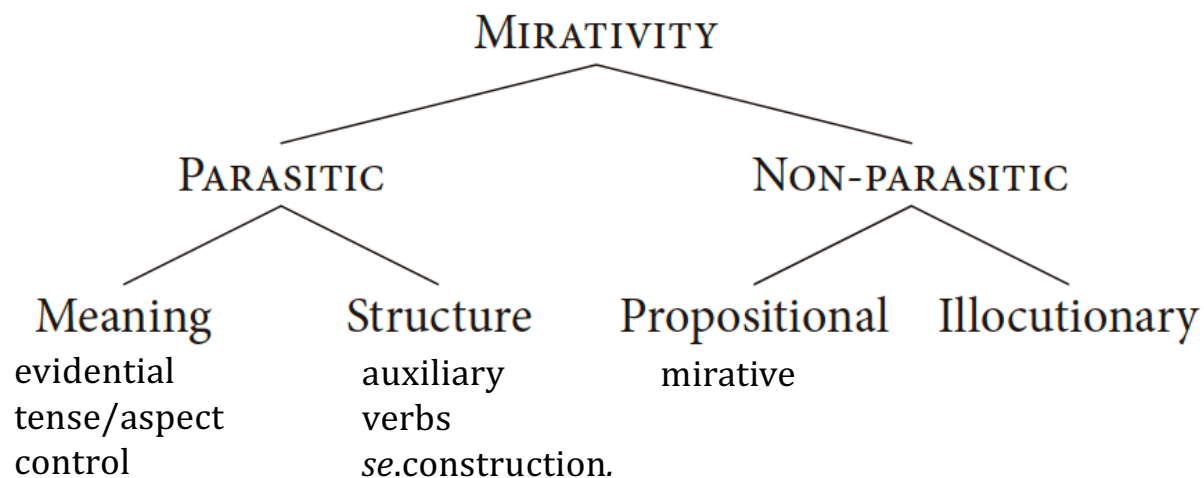
We use the term 'mirative'
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Why miratives are **unexpected**

Form

We use the term 'mirative'
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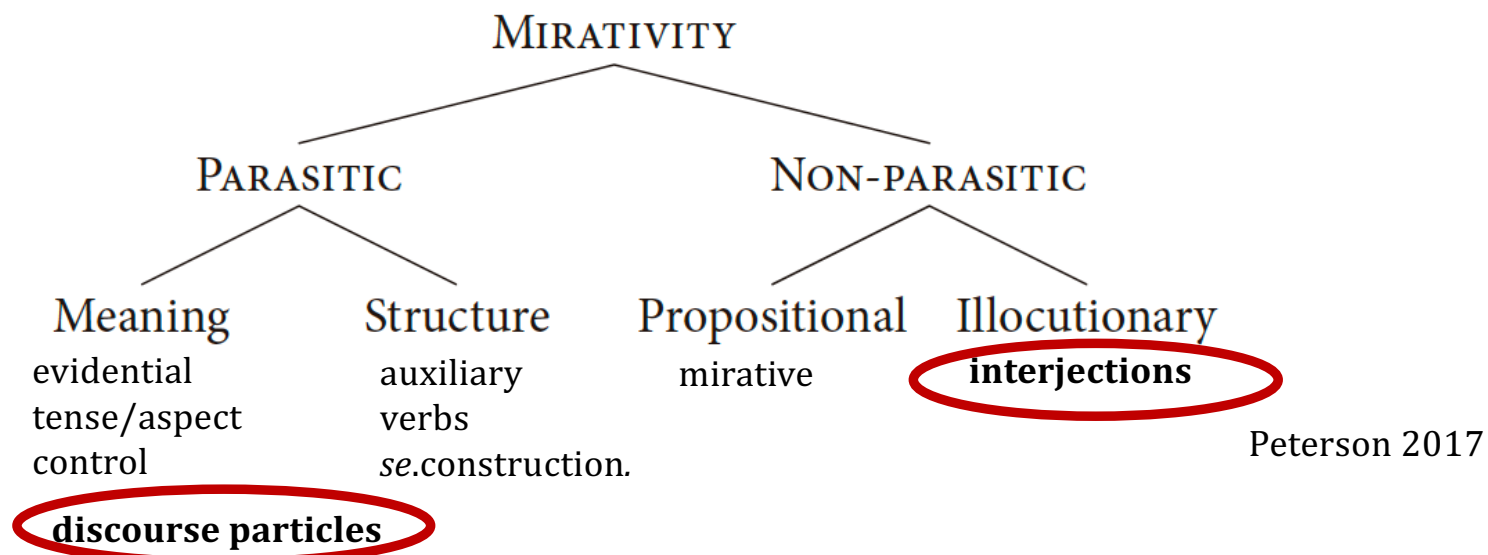
Peterson 2017

Why miratives are **unexpected**

Form

We use the term 'mirative'

as a label for any natural-language expression of exceeded expectation



2 mirative strategies in UAG

We can call them mirative strategies.



“interjection”

Ma wos moch-st’n du do schens?

MA what make-2SG-PRT 2SG there beautiful

‘What beautiful thing are you making?’

“discourse particle”

Du konn-st **leicht** zeichnen?

2SG can-2SG LEICHT draw

‘You can draw?’

Why miratives are unexpected

The universalist perspective

- A (universal) **sememe** (Rett 2021)
- **Not** a (universal) grammatical category (variation in marking)

Why miratives are unexpected

The universalist perspective

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Questions raised

- How do we analyse mirativity in light of their variation?
- What accounts for their universality?
- What accounts for the range of variation?

Why miratives are unexpected

The universalist perspective

- A (universal) **sememe** (Rett 2021)
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Questions raised

- How do we analyse mirativity in light of their variation?
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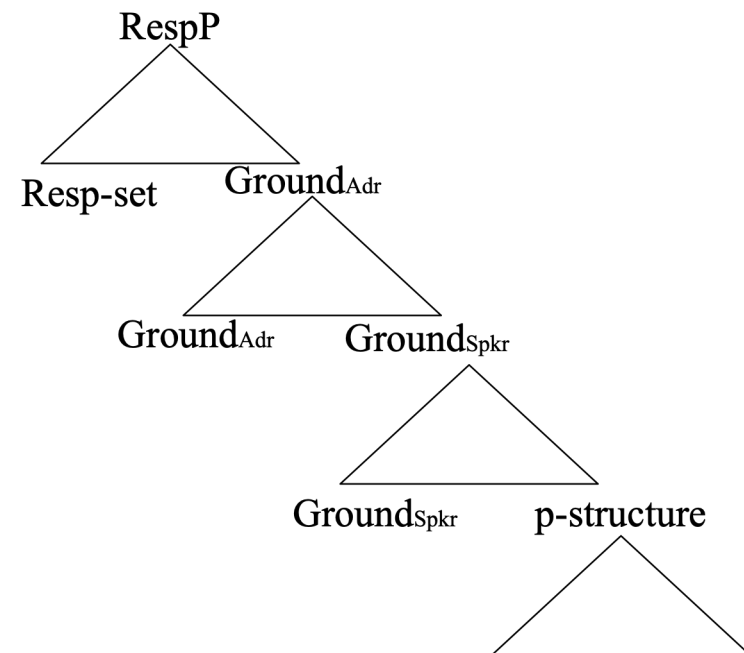
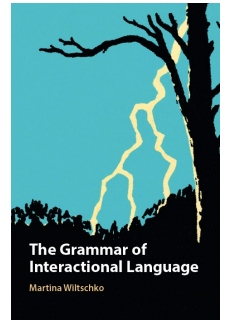
A methodological
problem of comparison!

Why miratives are expected

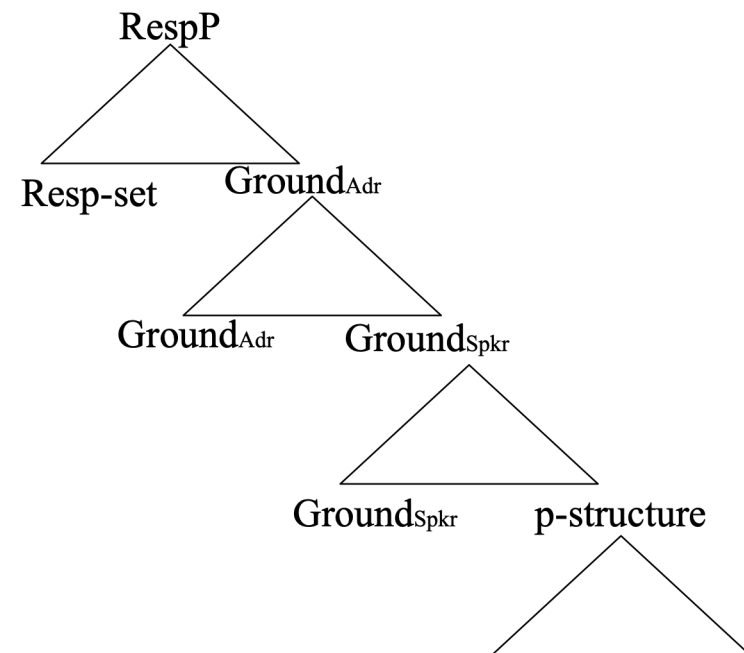
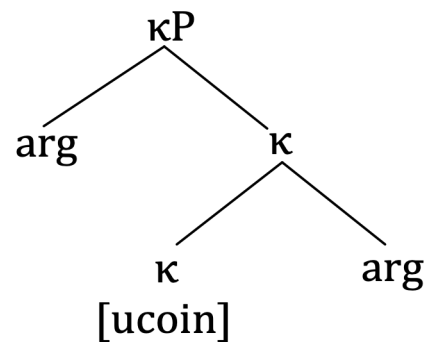
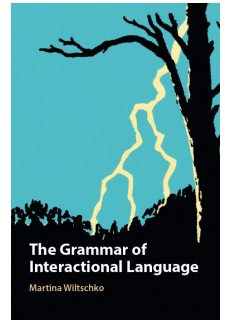
Part 1 The view from the interactional spine



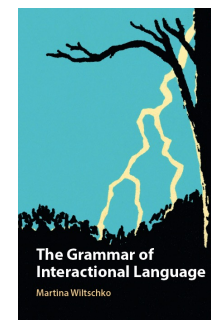
The interactional spine hypothesis



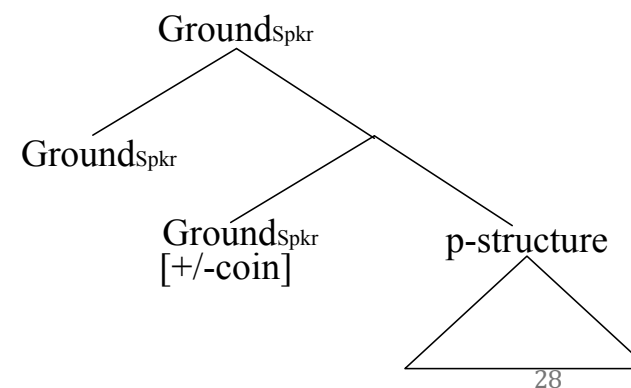
The interactional spine hypothesis



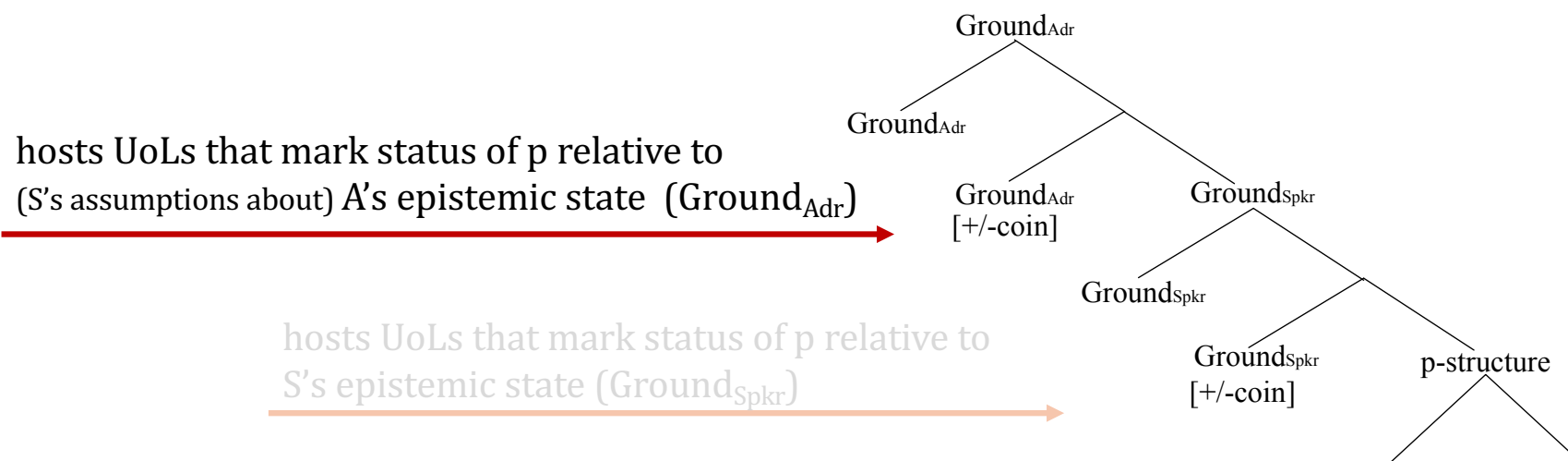
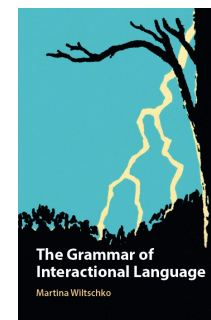
The interactional spine hypothesis



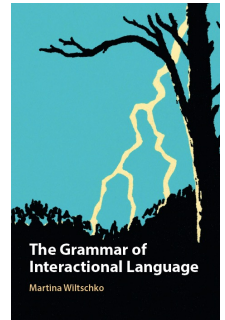
hosts UoLs that mark status of p relative to
S's epistemic state ($\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$)



The interactional spine hypothesis

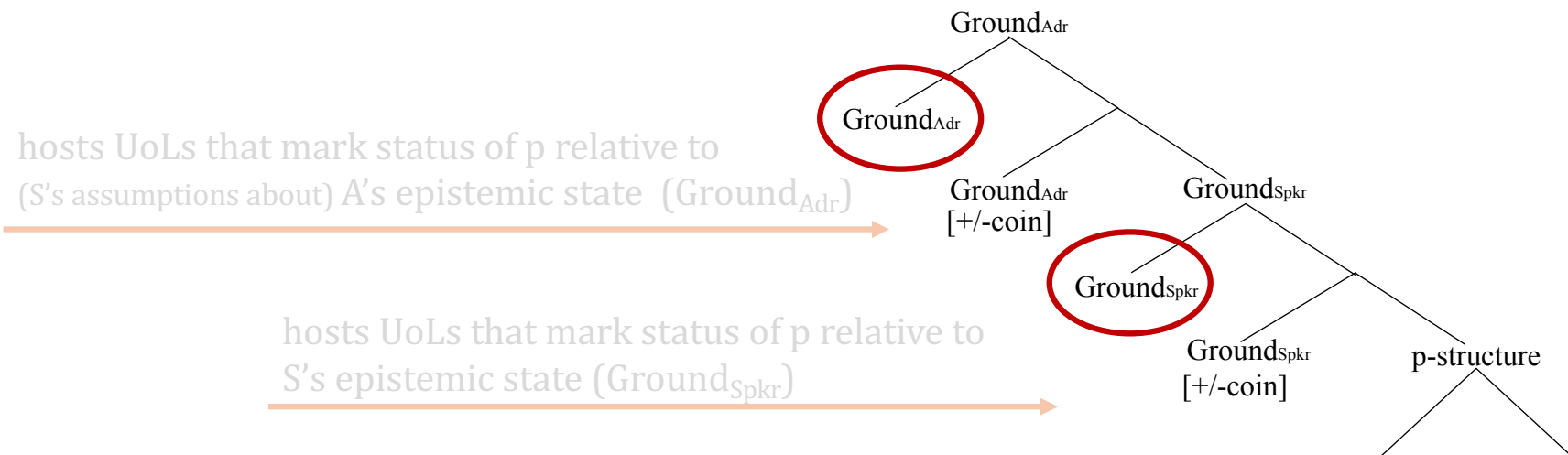


The interactional spine hypothesis

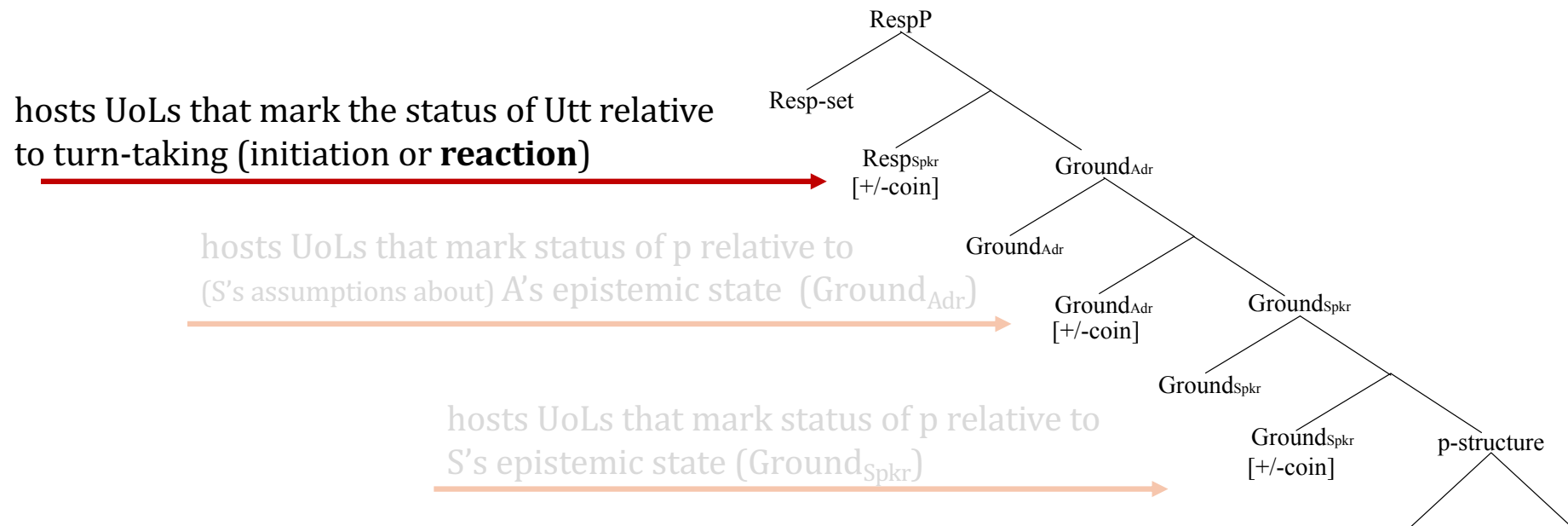
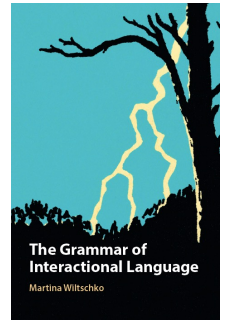


Ground =

grammatical placeholder for epistemic state of its holder (S or A)



The interactional spine hypothesis



The interactional spine hypothesis

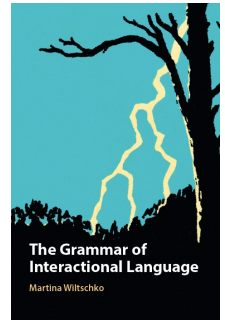
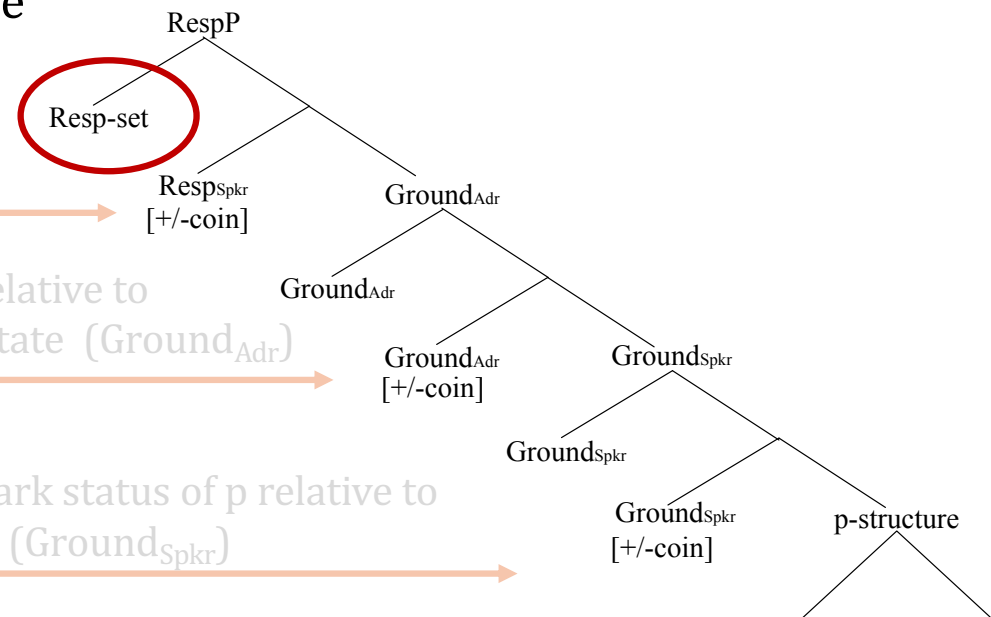
Resp-set

= grammatical placeholder for the table

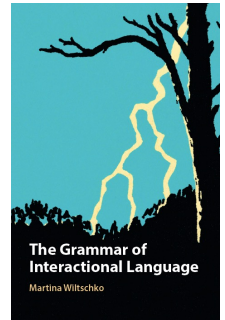
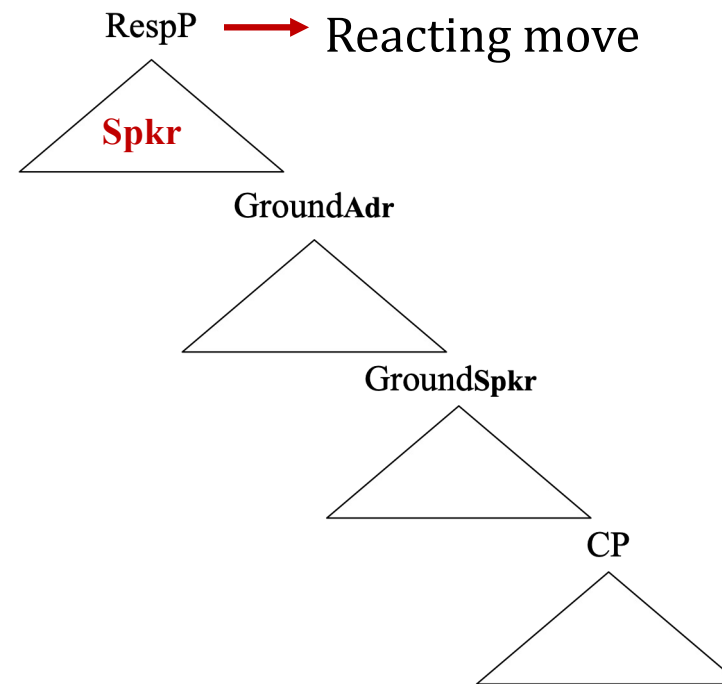
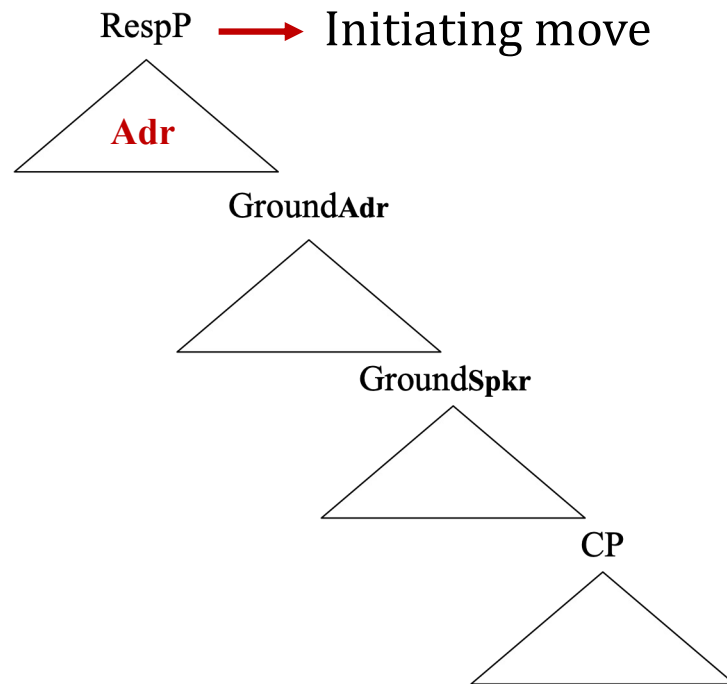
hosts UoLs that mark the status of Utt relative to turn-taking (initiation or **reaction**)

hosts UoLs that mark status of p relative to (S's assumptions about) A's epistemic state ($\text{Ground}_{\text{Adr}}$)

hosts UoLs that mark status of p relative to S's epistemic state ($\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$)



The interactional spine hypothesis





The syntax of talking heads

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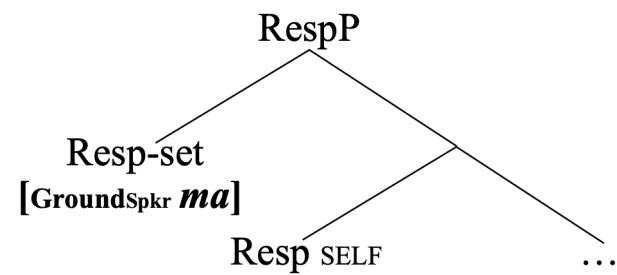


Why miratives are expected on the interactional spine

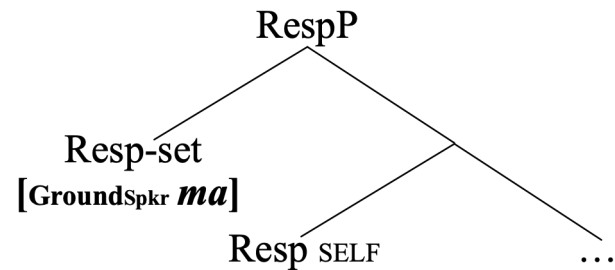
ma as Pro-Ground_{Spkr}

leicht values Ground_{Spkr}

ma as $\text{Pro-Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$



ma as Pro-Ground_{Spkr}



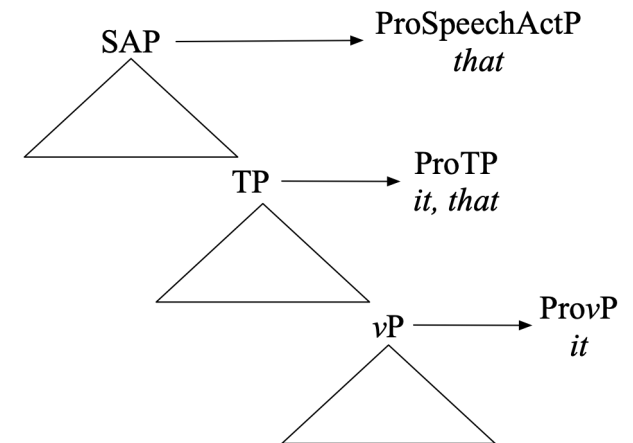
S's Ground is in S's response-set



possibly related to 1st person dative pronoun
ma (Standard *mir*)

Gib **ma** des!
Give 1DAT that
'Give me that!'

Other types of pro-forms



Ede stole the cookie. Bill saw **it**.

Ede stole the cookie. Bill knows **it**.

A: Ede stole the cookie.

B: **That's** a lie!

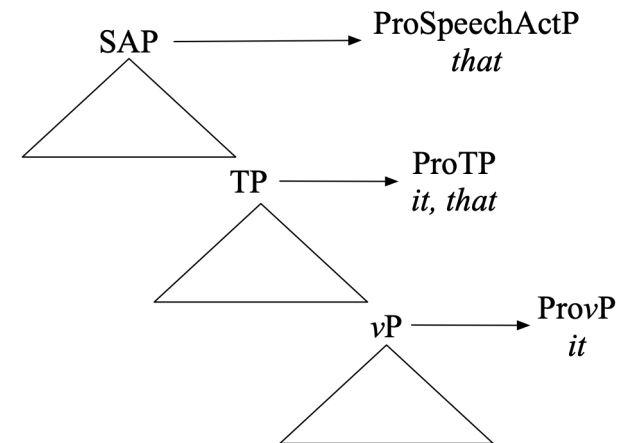
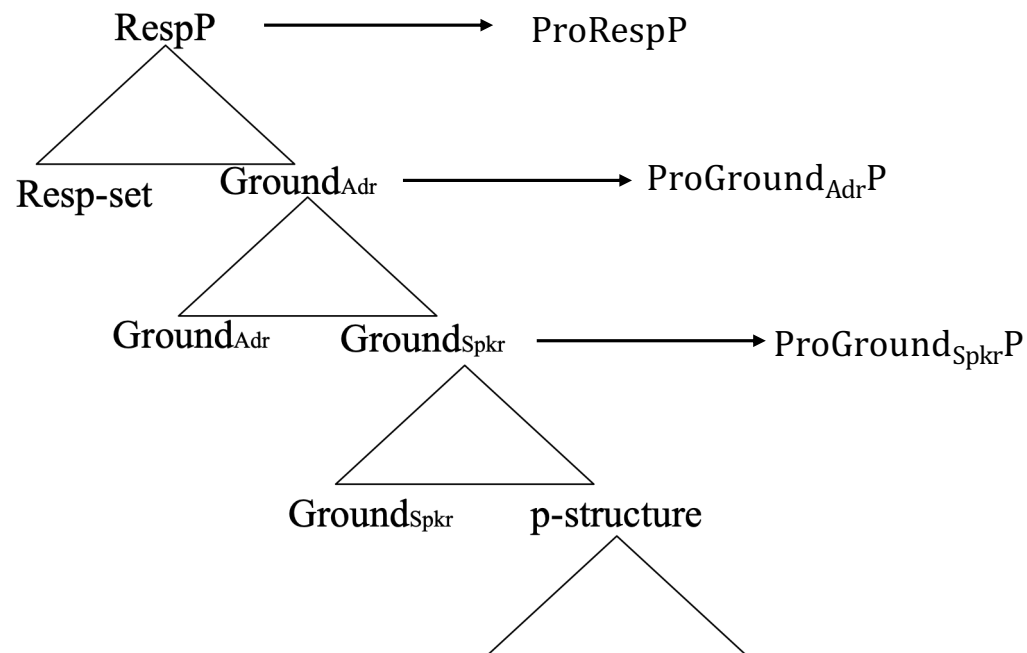
EVENT ANAPHOR

PROPOSITIONAL ANAPHOR

SPEECH-ACT ANAPHOR

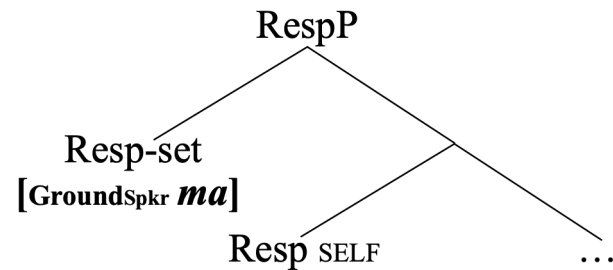
Krifka 2013: 4 (17-19)

Interactional pro-forms



ma as $\text{Pro-Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$

Meaning: surprise



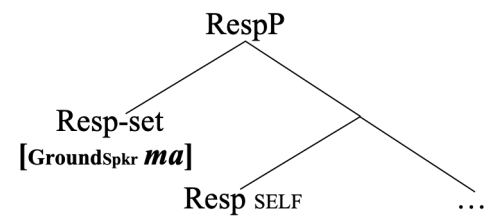
- S's epistemic state is cause for S's reaction
- Surprise is a reaction to one's own epistemic state
- ma is compatible with contexts of surprise but does not itself encode surprise

S's Ground is in S's response-set

ma as Pro-Ground_{Spkr}

Distribution:

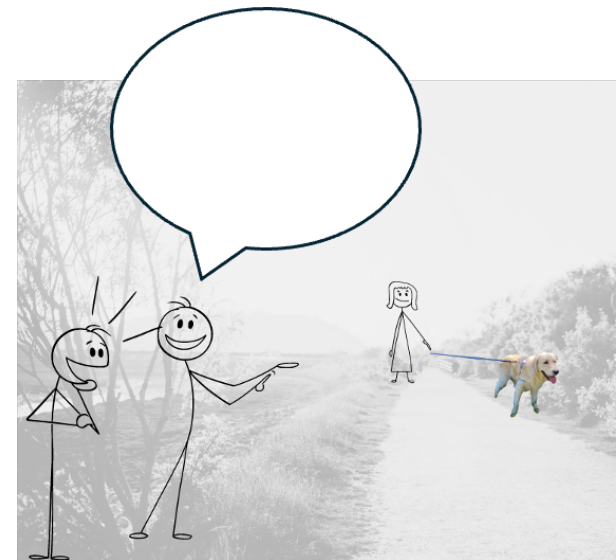
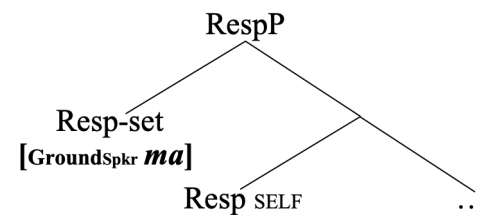
- stand alone



ma as Pro-Ground_{Spkr}

Distribution:

- stand alone
- turn initial



- Schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot an Hund.
 Look there over:there DET Lena has.3SG INDEF dog
 'Look over there. Lena has a dog.'
- Ma** schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot an Hund.
- Schau dort drüm. ***Ma** die Lena hot an Hund.

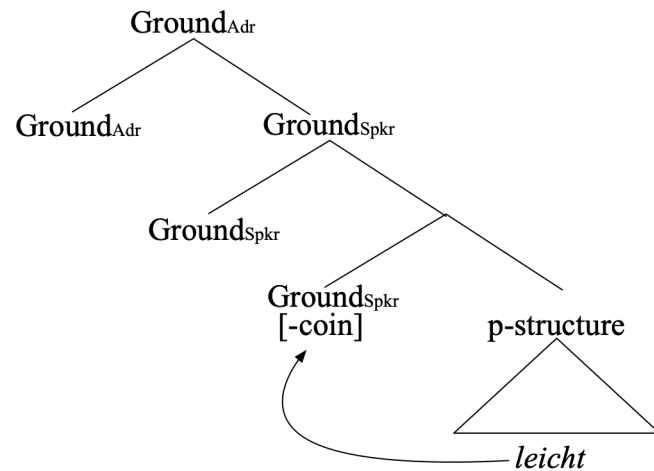
ma as Pro-Ground_{Spkr}

Distribution:

- stand alone
- turn initial
- not sensitive to clause-type

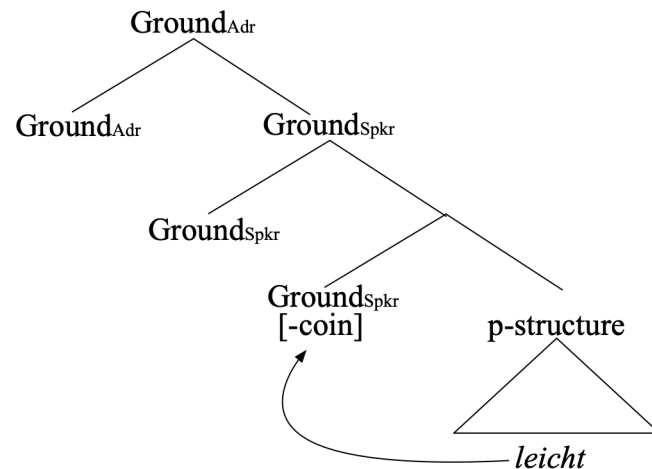
- | | | |
|----|---|---------------------|
| a. | Ma, die Lena hot an neichn Hund. | DECLARATIVE |
| | MA DET Lena has INDEF new dog | |
| | 'Lena has a new dog.' [I just realized that this is so] | |
| b. | Ma, gib da Lena an neichn Hund! | IMPERATIVE |
| | MA give DET Lena INDEF new dog | |
| | 'Give Lena a new dog.' [I just realized that this would be a good idea] | |
| c. | Ma, hot die Lena an neichn Hund? | POLAR INTERROGATIVE |
| | MA has DET Lena INDEF new dog | |
| | 'MA does Lena a new dog?' [I just realized that this might be the case.] | |
| d. | Ma, was hot die Lena fia an Hund? | WH-INTERROGATIVE |
| | MA what has DET Lena for INDEF dog | |
| | 'MA what kind of dog does Lena have?' [I just realized that she has one.] | |
| e. | Ma, was die Lena fia an Hund hot! | WH-EXCLAMATIVE |
| | Ma what DET Lena for INDEF dog has | |
| | 'MA what kind of dog Lena has!' [I just realized that she has one.] | |

leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ **[-coin]**



p is NOT in S's Ground

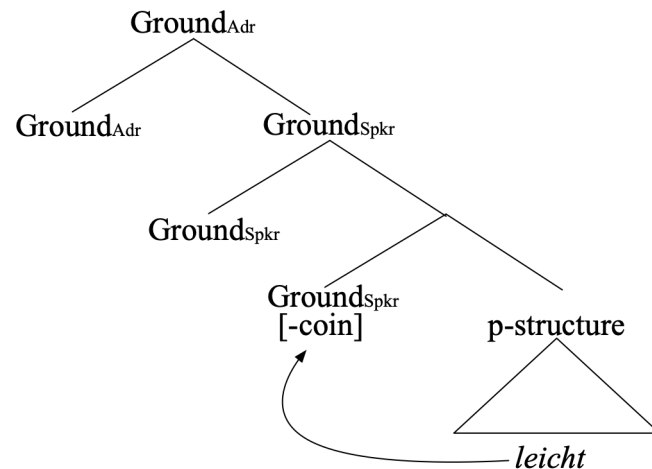
leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ [-coin]



p is NOT in S's Ground

- possibly (historically) related to *vielleicht* ('maybe')
- a. Er kann **vielleicht** zeichnen.
He can maybe draw
'Maybe he can draw.'
- b. Der kann **vielleicht** zeichnen!
DEM can maybe draw
'How well he can draw!'
- c. *Der kann **vielleicht** zeichnen!
DEM can maybe draw
'He can draw. (I didn't know that!).'

leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ [-coin]



p is NOT in S's Ground

- synchronically different

a. Dea ko **vielleicht/*leicht** zeichnen.

He can maybe draw

'Maybe he can draw.'

b. Der ko **vielleicht/*leicht** zeichnen!

DEM can maybe draw

'How well he can draw!'

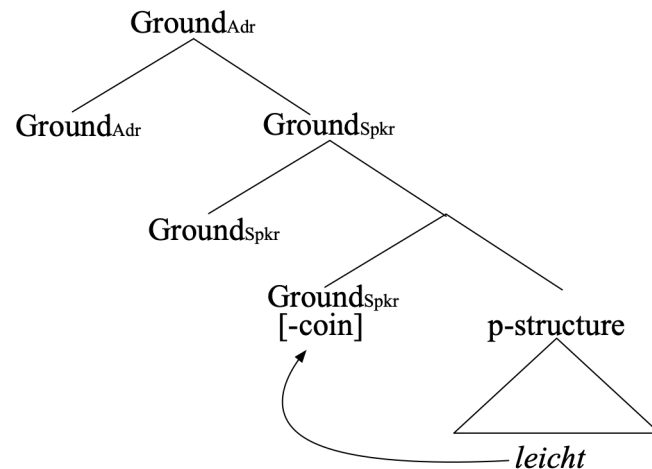
c. Der ko ***vielleicht/leicht** zeichnen!

DEM can maybe draw

'He can draw. (I didn't know that!).'

leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ [-coin]

Meaning: surprise



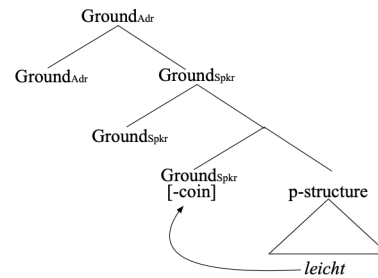
- p is marked as NOT being in S's ground
- *leicht* is compatible with contexts of surprise but does not itself encode surprise

p is NOT in S's Ground

leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ [-coin]

Distribution:

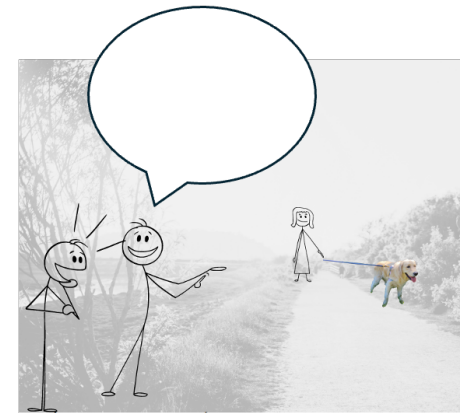
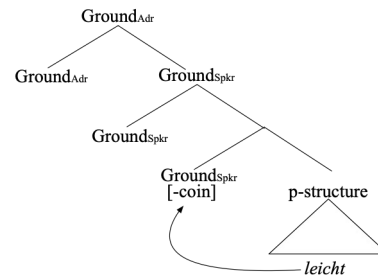
- cannot stand alone



leicht values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$ [-coin]

Distribution:

- cannot stand alone
- need not be turn-initial



- Schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot an Hund.
Look there over:there DET Lena has.3SG INDEF dog
'Look over there. Lena has a dog.'
- Ma** schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot an Hund.
- Schau dort drüm. ***Ma** die Lena hot an Hund.
- (Ma) schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot **leicht** an Hund

leicht values Ground_{Spkr} [-coin]

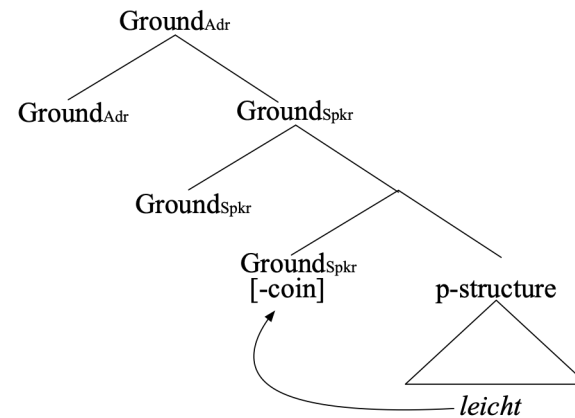
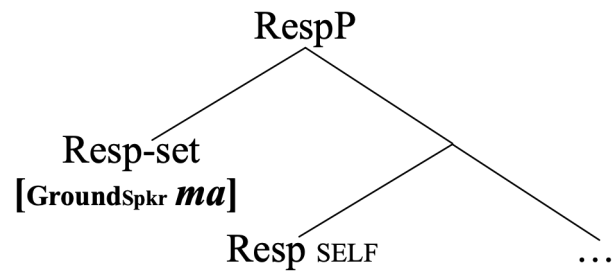
Distribution:

- cannot stand alone
- need not be turn-initial
- sensitive to clause-type

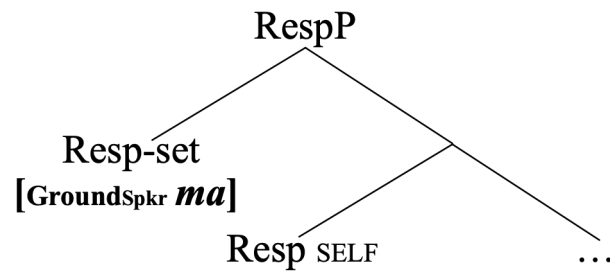
a.	Die Lena hot (leicht) an neichn Hund. DET Lena has (LEICHT) INDEF new dog 'Lena has a new dog.'	DECLARATIVE
b.	Gib da Lena (* leicht) an neichn Hund! give.IMP DET Lena (*LEICHT) INDEF new Hund 'Give Lena a new dog.'	IMPERATIVE
c.	Hot die Lena (leicht) an neichn Hund? has.3SG DET Lena (LEICHT) INDEF new dog 'Does Lena have a new dog?'	POLAR INTERROGATIVE
d.	Wos hot die Lena (leicht) fia an Hund? what has.3SG DET Lena (LEICHT) for INDEF dog 'What kind of dog does Lena have?'	WH-INTERROGATIVE
e.	Wos die Lena (* leicht) fia an Hund hot! What DET Lena (*LEICHT) for INDEF dog has.3SG 'What type of dog Lena has!'	WH-EXCLAMATIVE

What we expect from different miratives

Mirative strategies come about in different ways.



What we expect from different miratives

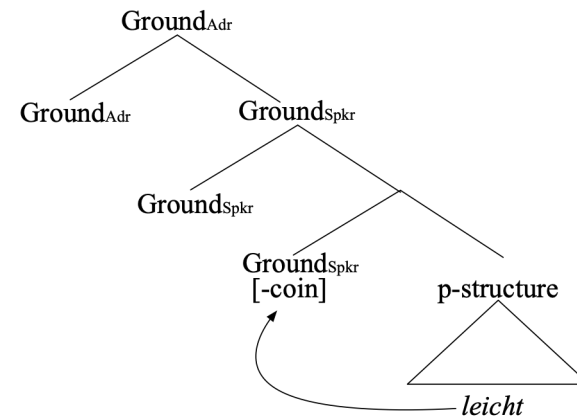


Predictions:

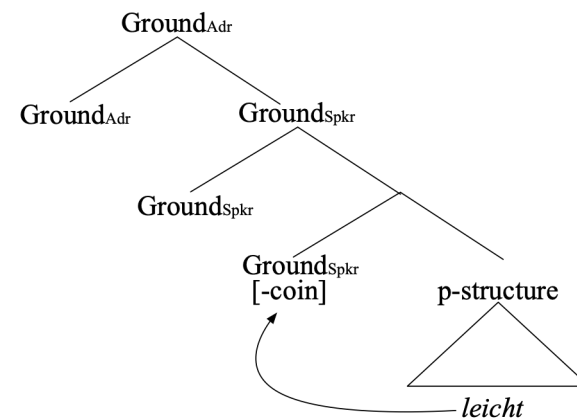
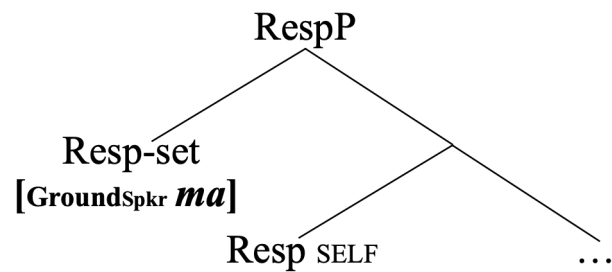
Different distribution

Different context of use

Different paradigmatic organization



Different distribution

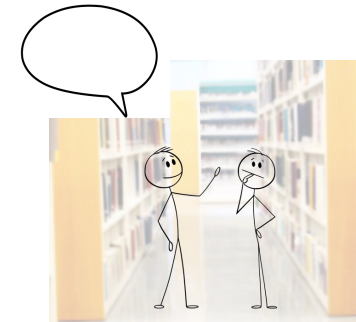


	<i>ma</i>	<i>leicht</i>
stand alone	✓	✗
sensitive to turn-shape	✓	✗
sensitive to clause-type	✗	✓

Different context of use

ma = reaction to S's epistemic state

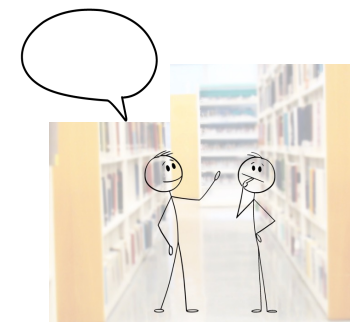
- (1) **Ma** do foit ma grod ei,
MA there falls 1SG.DAT just in
... I woit da dei buach zruckgem
I wanted 2SG.DAT 2SG.POSS book return
'I just remembered: I wanted to return your book.'



Different context of use

- (1) **Ma** do foit ma grod ei,
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ma = reaction to S's epistemic state



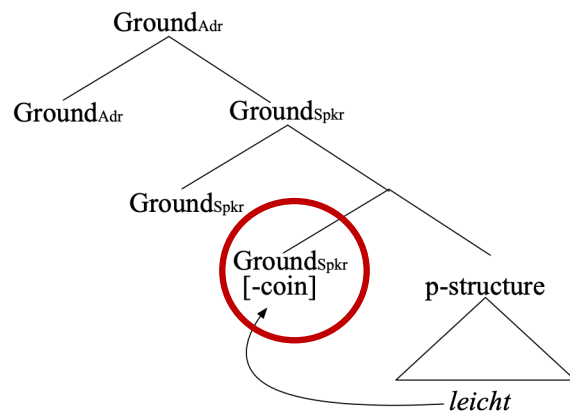
- (2) Do foit ma (***leicht**) grod ei,
there falls 1SG.DAT (LEICHT) just in,
I woit da dei buch zruckgem
I wanted 2SG.DAT 2SG.POSS book return
'I just remembered: I wanted to return your book.'

leicht marks p as not in S ground

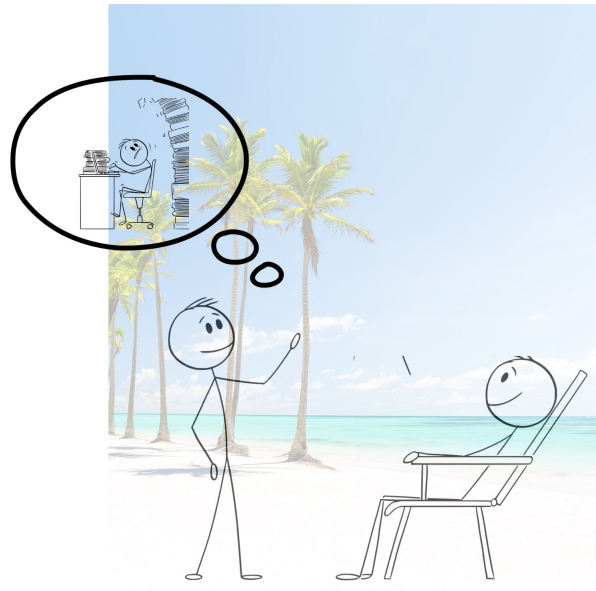
Different paradigmatic organization

Contrast in valuation

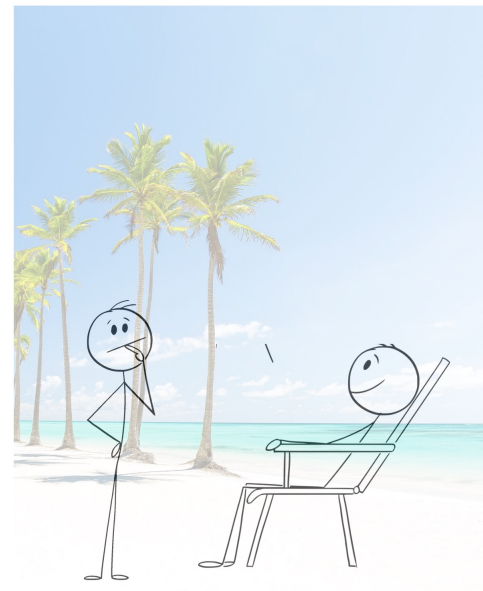
Is there [+coin]?



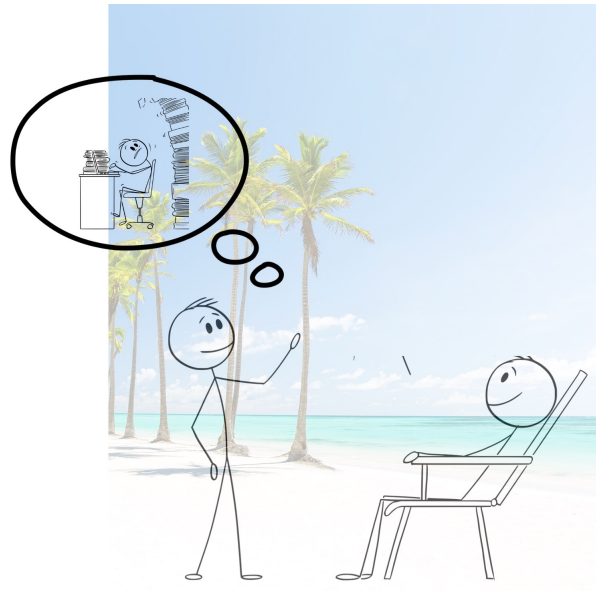
leicht vs. hoit



Warum oabeit-st'n du ned?
Why. work-2SG'PRT 2SG NEG
'Why don't you work?'



leicht vs. hoit



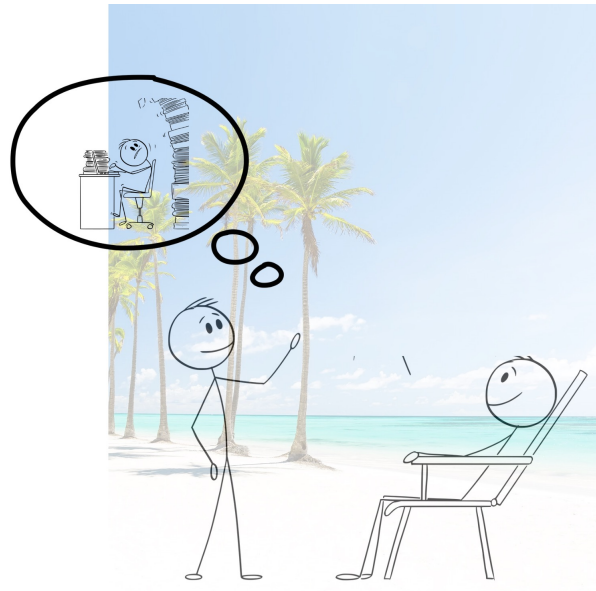
Warum oabeit-st'n du ned?
 Why. work-2SG'PRT 2SG NEG
 'Why don't you work?'



I hob **hoit** ka Lust.
 1SG have HALT no desire
 'I'm not in the mood.'

adapted from Bross (2012:192)

leicht vs. hoit

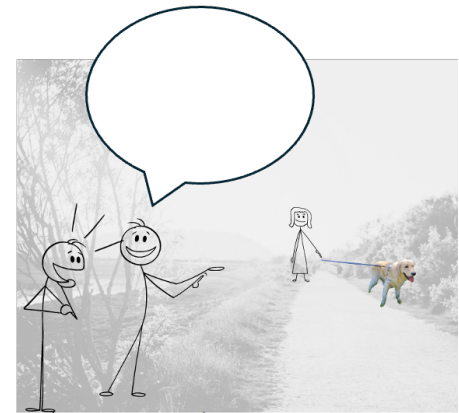


Warum oabeit-st'n du ned?
 Why. work-2SG'PRT 2SG NEG
 'Why don't you work?'



*I hob **leicht** ka Lust.
 I have LEICHT no. desire
 'I'm not in the mood.'

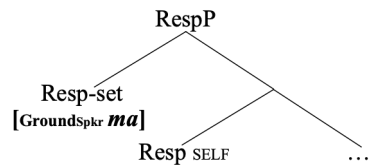
leicht vs. hoit



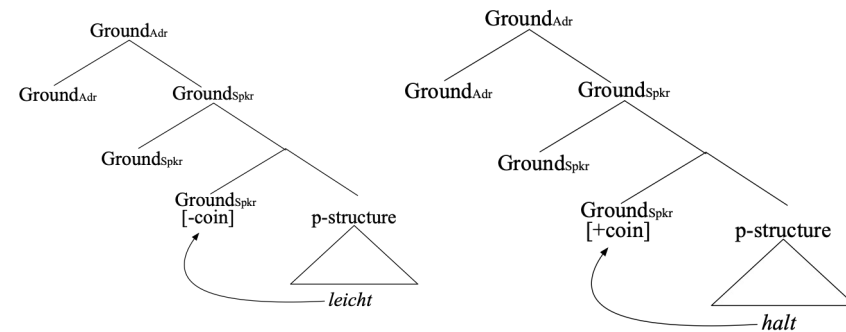
- a. (Ma) schau dort drüm. Die Lena hot **leicht** an Hund
MA. Look there over:there DET Lena has LEICHT INDEF dog
'Look over there. Lena has a dog.'
- b. (Ma) schau dort drüm. *Die Lena hot **hoit** an Hund.

ma lacks this contrast

***Ma** does not have this contrast*



There is no Utt-initial interjection marking **expectedness**



ma lacks this contrast

***Ma** does not have this contrast*

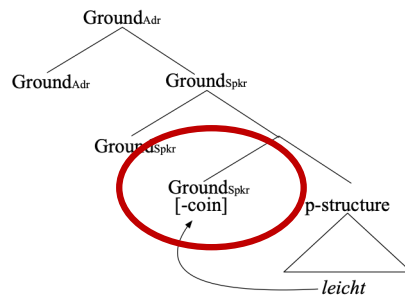
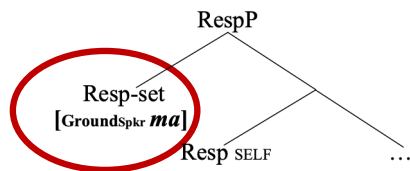
There is no principled restriction on this contrast

- a. Zhangsan jingran lai le
Zhangsan JINGRAN come PRC
'Zhangsan came.' (contrary to expectation)
- b. Zhangsan guoran lai le
Zhangsan GUORAN come PRC
'Zhangsan came.' (as expected)

(Wu 2008: 103 (6a/7a))

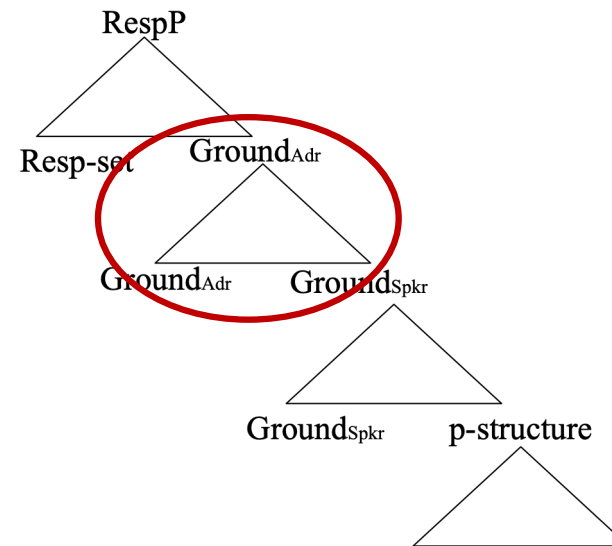
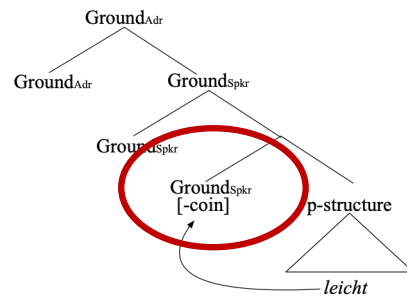
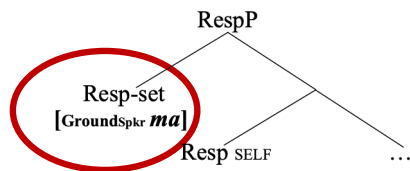
Different paradigmatic organization

Are there A-oriented cases?



Contrast in S- vs. A- orientation

Are there A-oriented cases?



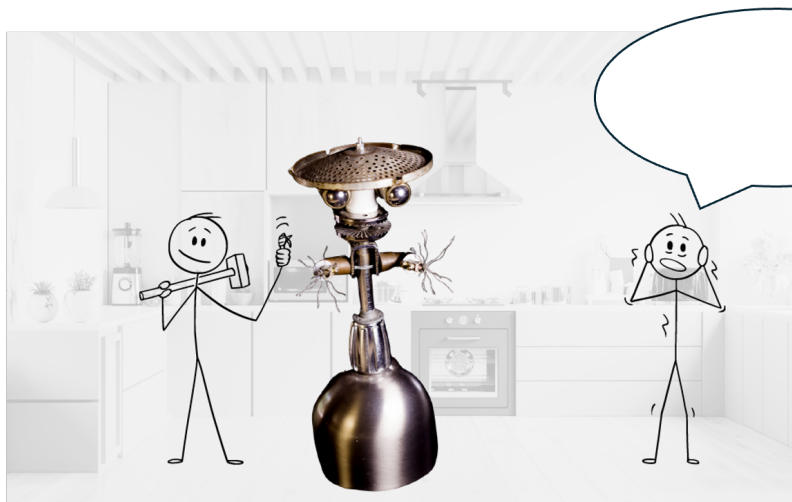
Pro-Ground_{Adr}P

Context 2

Thea sees her friend making an awkward contraption that takes up a lot of space in their shared kitchen.

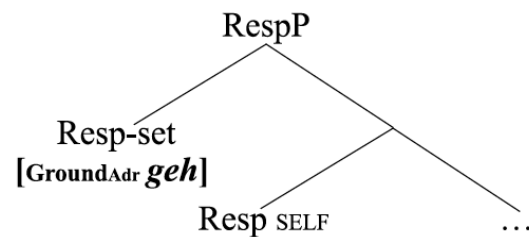


geh



Geh wos moch-st'n du do fia an Bledsinn?
GEH what make-2SG.PRT 2SG there for INDEF nonsense
'What stupid thing are you doing?'

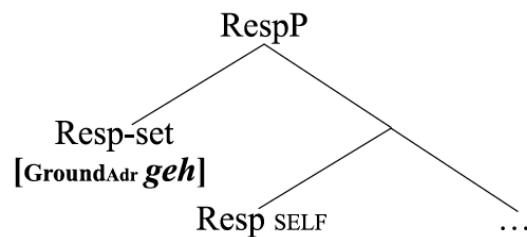
geh as Pro-Ground_{Adr}P



Geh wos moch-st'n du do fia an Bledsinn?
GEH what make-2SG.PRT 2SG there for INDEF nonsense
'What stupid thing are you doing?'

A's Ground is in S's response-set

geh as $\text{Pro-Ground}_{\text{Adr}}\text{P}$



probably related to **imperative** form of *gehen* ('go')

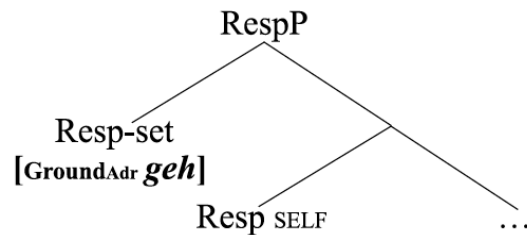
A's Ground is in S's response-set

Geh endlich ham!
Go finally home
'Go home at last!'

geh as $\text{Pro-Ground}_{\text{Adr}}\text{P}$



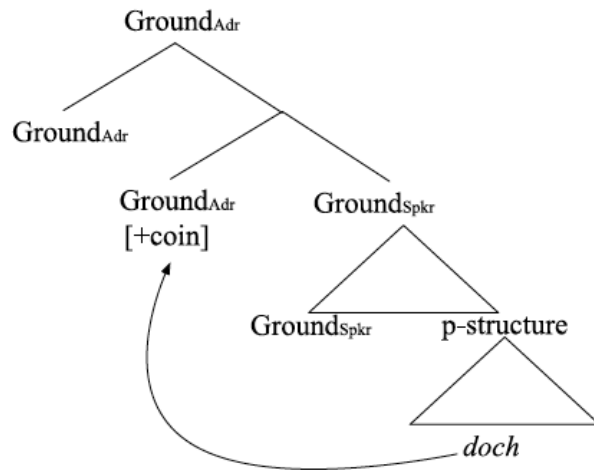
Meaning: annoyance



- A's epistemic state is cause of S's reaction
- One reason to react to A's epistemic state is when it differs from S's.
- *geh* is compatible with contexts of discrepancy
- since it marks a reaction, it has the flavour of mirativity

A's Ground is in S's response-set

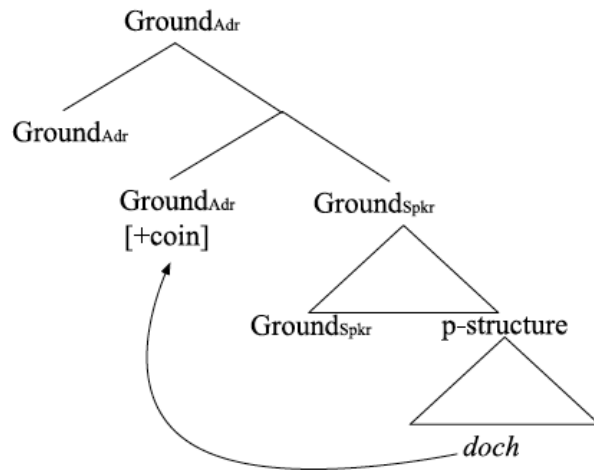
doch values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Adr}}$ [+coin]



p is in A's Ground

Des kann-st **doch** do ned mochn!
That can-2SG DOCH there not do
'But you can't do that there.'
(indicating disapproval)

doch values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Adr}}$ [+coin]



p is in A's Ground

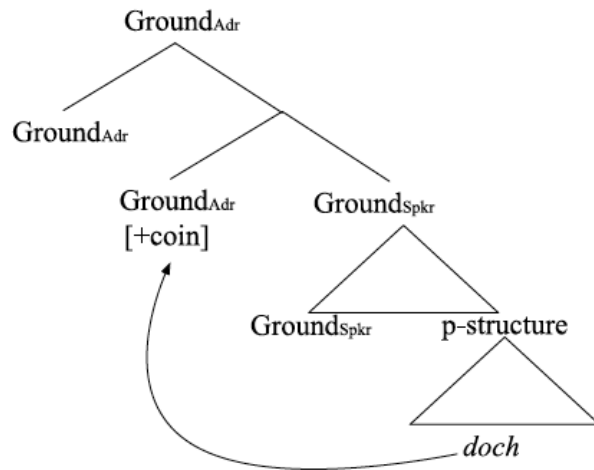
- *doch* can also be used as **positive response marker** answering negative questions, response to negative assertions

A: Host du kan Hunga!
Have-2SG you no hunger
'Aren't you hungry?'

B: Doch
'I am hungry.'

doch values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Adr}}$ [**+coin**]

Meaning: A (should) know p



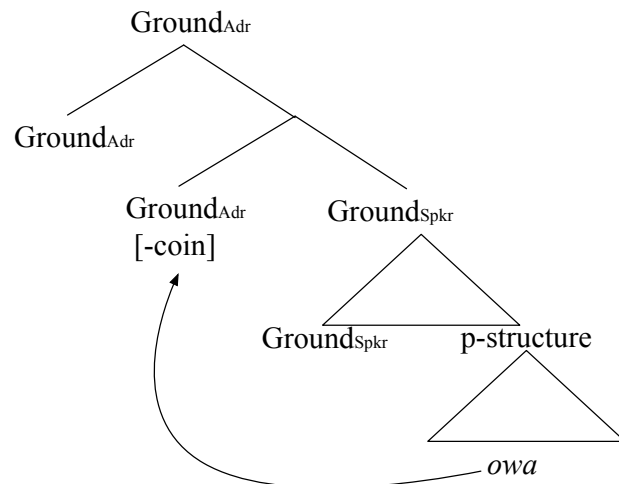
p is in A's Ground

- p is marked as being in A's ground
- *doch* is **compatible** with contexts of surprise but does not itself encode surprise

Geh, des kann-st **doch** do ned mochn!
GEH that can-2SG DOCH there not do
'But you can't do that there.'
(indicating disapproval)

owa values $\text{Ground}_{\text{Adr}}$ [-coin]

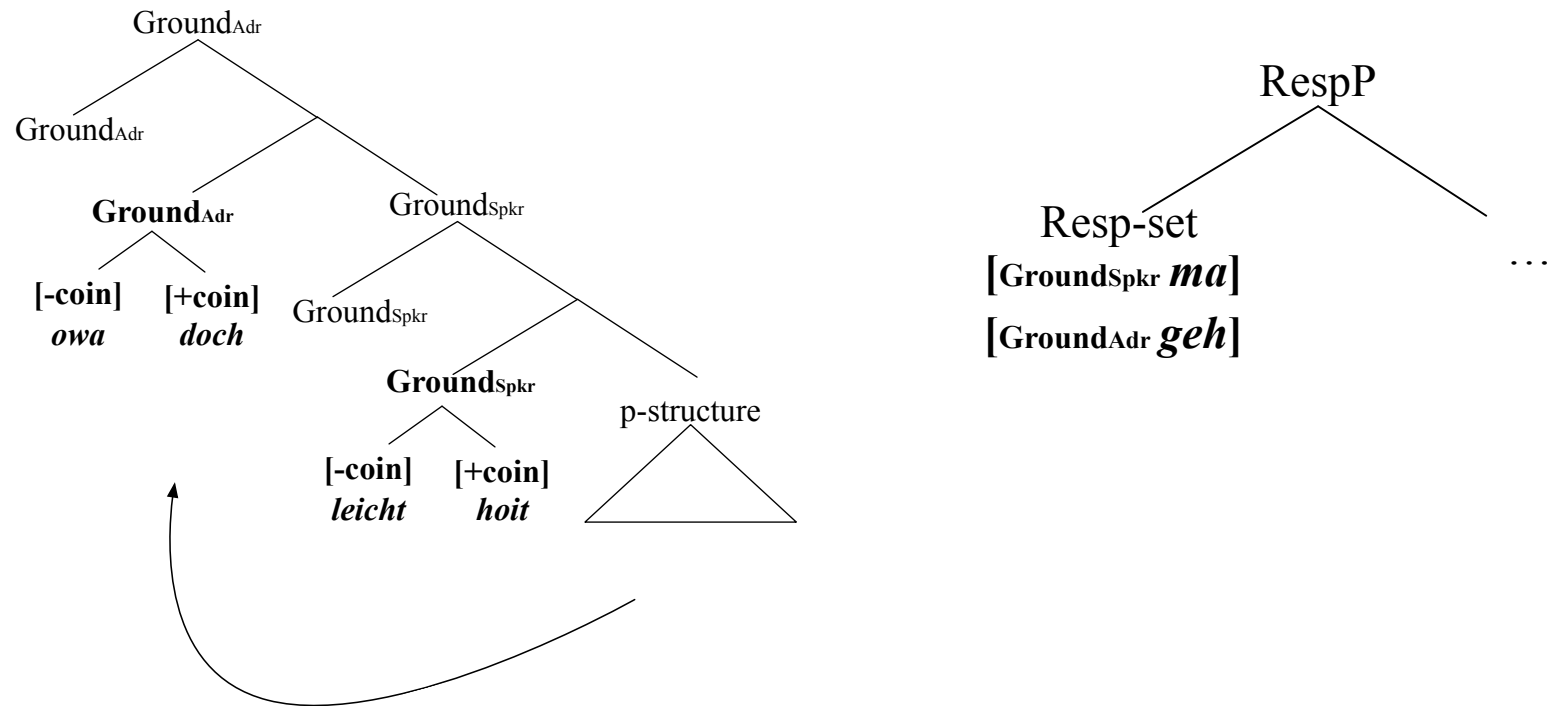
Meaning: A does not know p



p is in not in A's Ground

Des kannst **owa** do ned mochn! [UAG]
that can-2SG OWA there not do
'You can't do that there.'

Different paradigmatic organization



	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			
Bavarian					fei	
Swabian	ach				oba	
	heh					
Norddeutsch	oh	aber				
Standard	ach na sowas wow boah	aber	etwa echt tatsächlich		aber	
	ey					

Strategies in other German varieties

Work in progress

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			

*Du konn-st **leicht** zeichnen. (DECLARATIVE)

you can-2sg LEICHT draw

‘You can draw’

Konnst du **leicht** zeichnen? (INTERROGATIVE)

Konnst du **eppa** zeichnen?

P. Grosz, p.c.



eppa

vielleicht

Erstellt von: System32

Erstellt am: 28.06.2005

Bekanntheit: 49%

Bewertungen: 16 2

eppa

etwa, tatsächlich

Erstellt von: pedrito

Erstellt am: 21.06.2006

Bekanntheit: 13%

Bewertungen: 4 0



Super Eintrag, aber mit der Übersetzung

tu ich mir schwer. Falsch ist sie nicht, aber sie greift m.E. zu kurz. "Etwa" oder "gar" trifft's besser, kommt mir vor, weil in eppa ein Element der Verwunderung enthalten ist.

klaser 30.10.2007

Burgenland



Konstantin@TheAUTcast says:

7th September 2018 at 12:23 pm

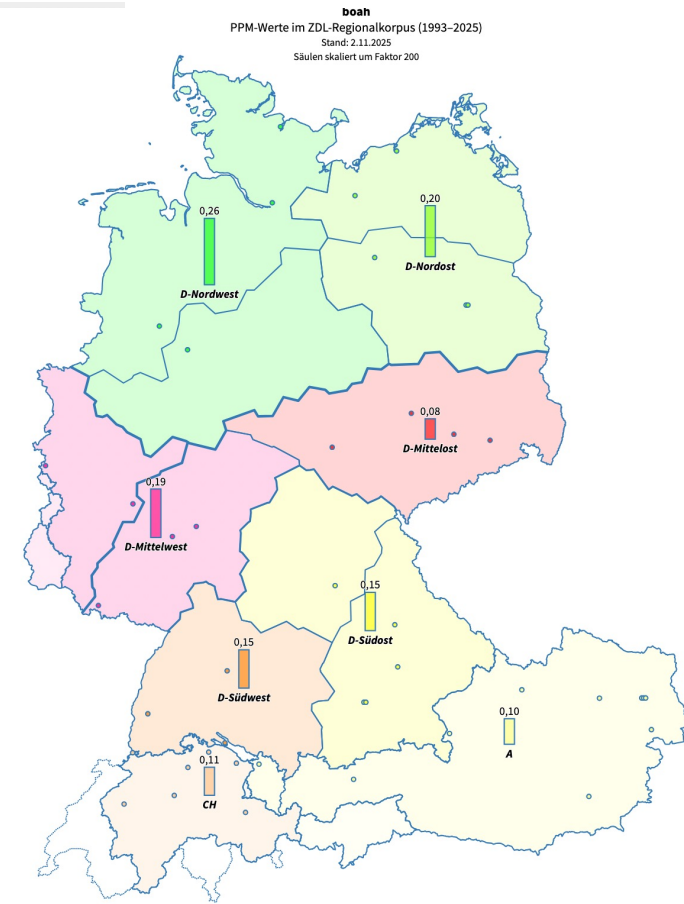
eppa – It's not used all over Austria and I can only speak for Burgenland on this matter but it basically means “vielleicht” or “maybe/may”.

To give an example: “wüßt eppa nochha no wos mochn?” “Willst du vielleicht nachher noch etwas unternehmen/machen?”

<https://blogs.fcdo.gov.uk/leighturner/2018/09/07/when-austrian-german-is-the-best/#comments>

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			

- 3: [Nationaler Programm-Wettbewerb über Naturerbe und andere Themen. Nationaler Prog, 2013-12-20](#)
Boah da hätt ich “fast” umgeschaltet.
- 4: [Jung von Matt zeigt ein Dekoltee-Foto und alle rasten aus. Jetzt zeige ich euch meine Titten!. Blogrebelln, 2013-12-10](#)
Boah Peter, Junge, mache dein Foto raus aus dem Internet.
- 5: [Entweder, dies ist mein allerletzter Blogeintrag, oder.... Que Onda?, 2013-12-08](#)
Boah , mein lieber Scholli wenn's denn kommt , kommt's wirklich dicke
- 6: [\(How to\) - Entsaften ohne Entsafter. Wilde-Wölfin, 2013-12-04](#)
Boah, das ist doch zu arbeitsintensiv....;)
- 7: [Blutige Spätzle. Wassilys Weisheiten, 2013-11-26](#)
Boah, wer putzt anschliessend?
- 8: [Menschenarten: Kopulation mit unbekannter Population. Brights - Die Natur des Zweifels, 2013-11-20](#)
Boah, wie ich diese falschen Freunde hasse:
- 9: [Hogwarts an der Uni Freiburg: Spiritualität-Studium. Brights - Die Natur des Zweifels, 2013-11-10](#)
 „**Boah**, fühlt sich das gut an!“, „Mir geht es wirklich besser“ und „Genial!“ lauten die Urteile.
- 10: [Schönes Wochenende!. Que Onda?, 2013-10-26](#)
Boah!
- 11: [Der Freitagswitz - Erstelle Deinen ECHTEN eignen Twitter-Hashtag und das noch Gratis!. Upgrade zum Geschäftsmann 2.0, 2013-10-18](#)
Boah, auf <http://hashtagsetup.com/> kann man sich gratis einen eigenen Hashtag machen lassen!
- 12: [Kürbis- und Kichererbsensalat mit Tahini-Sauce. Lamiacucina, 2013-10-15](#)
Boah das sieht aber überaus köstlich aus!
- 13: [Me made Mittwoch: Rotes Jurk. Siebenhundertsachen, 2013-10-15](#)
Boah, das ist dreist.
- 14: [Gams Entrecôte mit Quarkspätzli und Rosmarin-Birne. Lieberlecker, 2013-10-03](#)
Boah!
- 15: [der gepflegte Wutausbruch am Montag. Blogrebelln, 2013-09-23](#)
Boah, bin ich sauer!
- 16: [der gepflegte Wutausbruch am Montag. Blogrebelln, 2013-09-23](#)
Boah, bin ich sauer!
- 17: [Support your local Ghetto - DJ Tools workshop with Mad Zach \(Freikarte\). Blogrebelln, 2013-09-21](#)
Boah, bin ich aufgeregt.



https://www.dwds.de/r/?corpus=dwdsxl&q=boah&sc=adg&sc=blogs&sc=bundestag&sc=bz&sc=ddr&sc=gesetze&sc=kern&sc=kern21&sc=politische_reden&sc=spk&sc=tsp&sc=untertitel

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			
Bavarian					fei	



Des konn-st **fei** do ned macha!
 That can-2SG FEI there not do
 'But you can't do that there.'
 (you don't seem to know that)

Sonja Thoma, p.c.

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			
Bavarian					fei	
Swabian	ach					
	heh					



Heh, was machssch'n du do?



Heh, du kosch jo male!

J.Heim, p.c.

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
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	heh					
Norddeutsch	oh	aber				

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
UAG	ma boah	geh	leicht	hoit	owa	doch
Burgenland			%leicht eppa			
Bavarian					fei	
Swabian	ach				oba	
	heh					
Norddeutsch	oh	aber				
Standard	ach na sowas wow boah	aber	etwa echt tatsächlich		aber	
	ey					

na sowas

(*Na sowas). Was machst du denn dort schönes?

what make-2SG-PRT 2SG there beautiful

‘What beautiful thing are you making?’



Na sowas. Du kann-st zeichnen

2SG can-2SG draw

‘Wow. You can draw?’

na sowas implies that you already know.

The question cannot be information-seeking.

I. Feldhausen, p.c.

	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
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	heh					
Norddeutsch	oh	aber				
Standard	ach na sowas wow boah	aber	etwa echt tatsächlich		aber	
	ey					

Rechtschreibung

Bedeutungen

Herkunft

DUDEN Mentor

Textkorrekturen
auf Knopfdruck
durch KI

Mentor Klassik

Neu

KI-Assistent

JETZT TESTEN

Alle neuen
Rechtschreibregeln.

JETZT ENTDECKEN

DIE DEUTSCHE
RECHTSCHREIBUNG

Bedeutungen (2) ⓘ

1. Ausruf, der Erstaunen, Überraschung ausdrückt

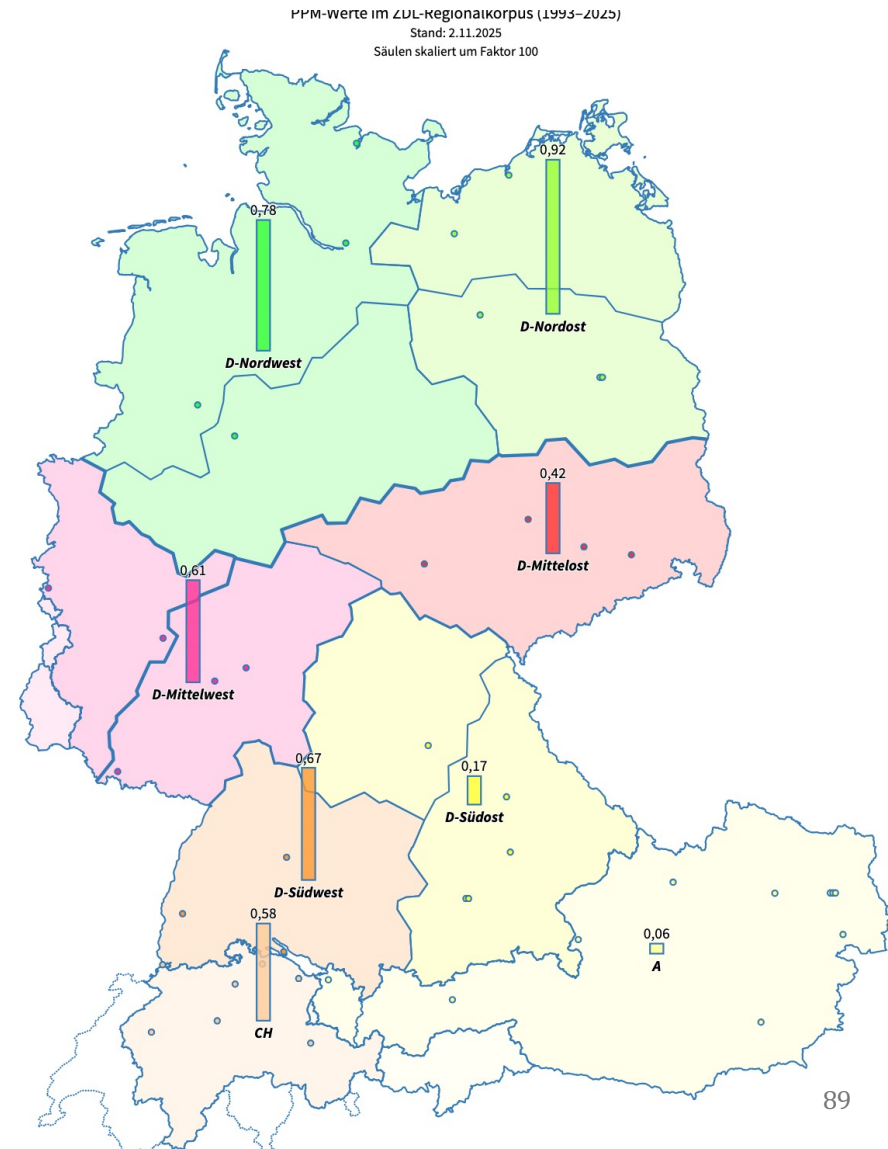
BEISPIEL

- ey, das ist cool!

2. Ausruf, der Empörung, Abwehr ausdrückt

BEISPIEL

- ey, Mann, das kannst du doch nicht machen!



Eh vs. huh



You have a new dog, **eh**?
You have a new dog, **huh**?

Eh vs. huh



You have a new dog, **eh**?
You have a new dog, **huh**?

Du host an neichn Hund, **oda**?
Du host an neichn Hund, **geu**?

Eh vs. huh



I have a new dog, **eh**?
*I have a new dog, **huh**?

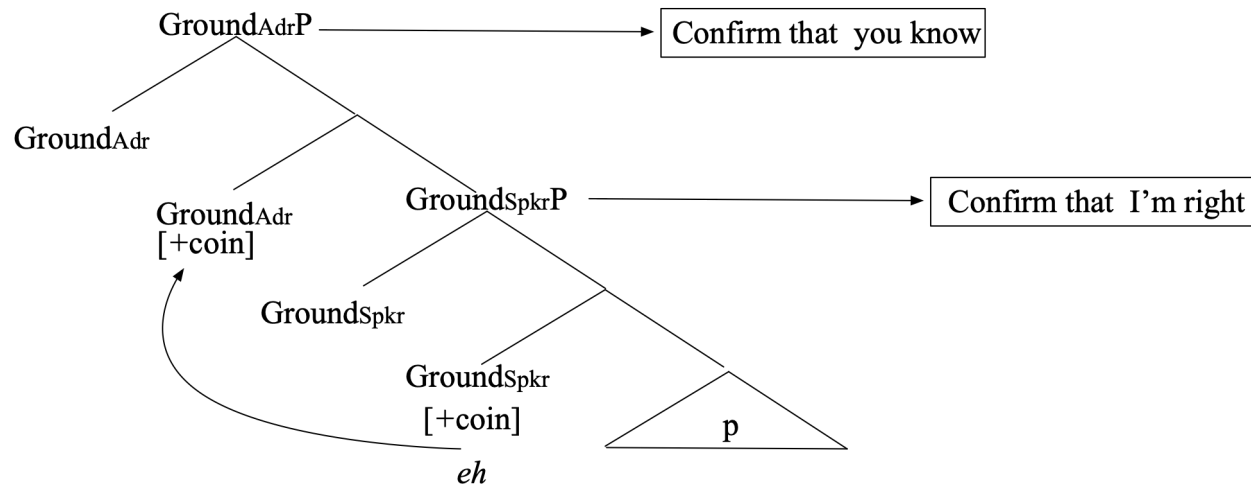
Eh vs. huh



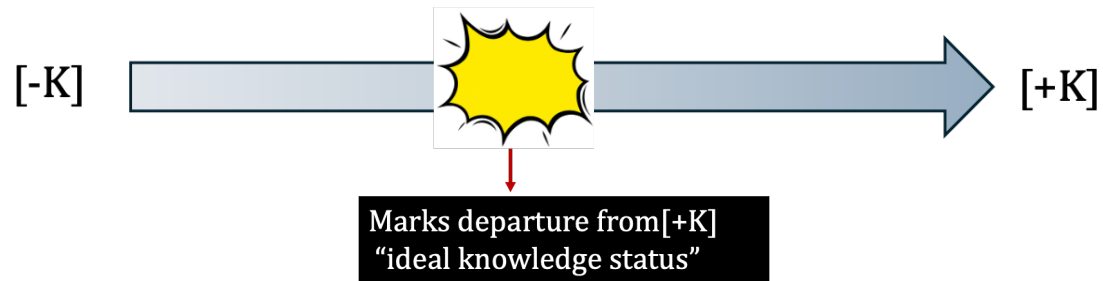
I have a new dog, **eh**?
*I have a new dog, **huh**?

*I hob an neichn Hund, **oda**?
I hob an neichn Hund, **geu**?

The multi-functionality of eh



	Pro Ground _{Spkr}	Pro Ground _{Adr}	Ground _{Spkr} [-coin]	Ground _{Spkr} [+coin]	Ground _{Adr} [-coin]	Ground _{Adr} [+coin]
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	ey					

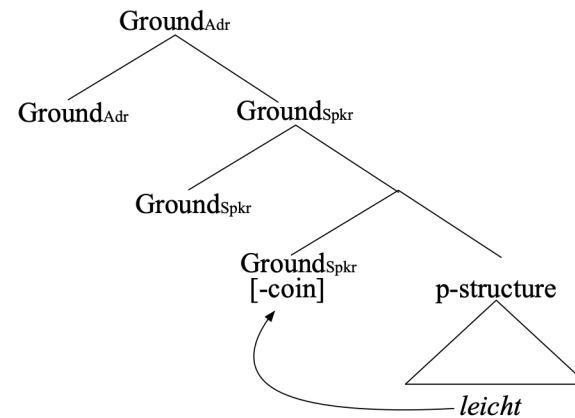
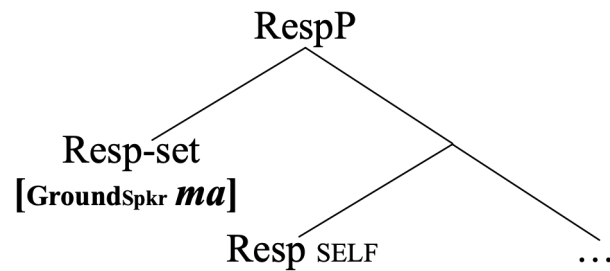


Why miratives are (un)expected

A recap of the problem

Why miratives are (un)expected

Mirative strategies come about in different ways.



Different distribution

Different context of use

Different paradigmatic organization

But why?

Why miratives are (un)expected

The universalist perspective

- A (universal) **sememe** (Rett 2021)
- **Not** a (universal) grammatical category (variation in marking)

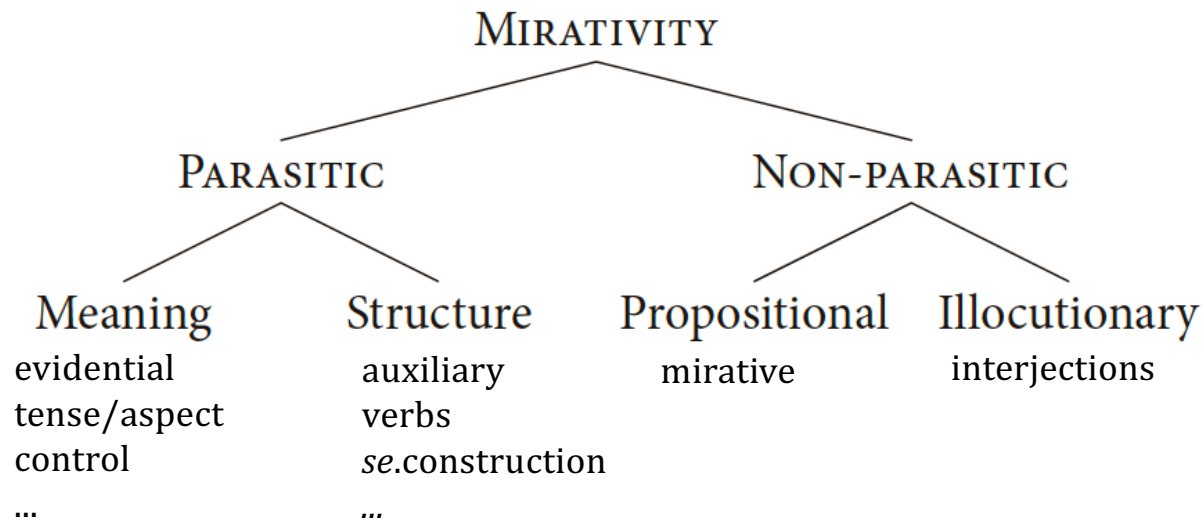
But why?

Why miratives are (un)expected

Form

We use the term 'mirative'

as a label for any natural-language expression of exceeded expectation



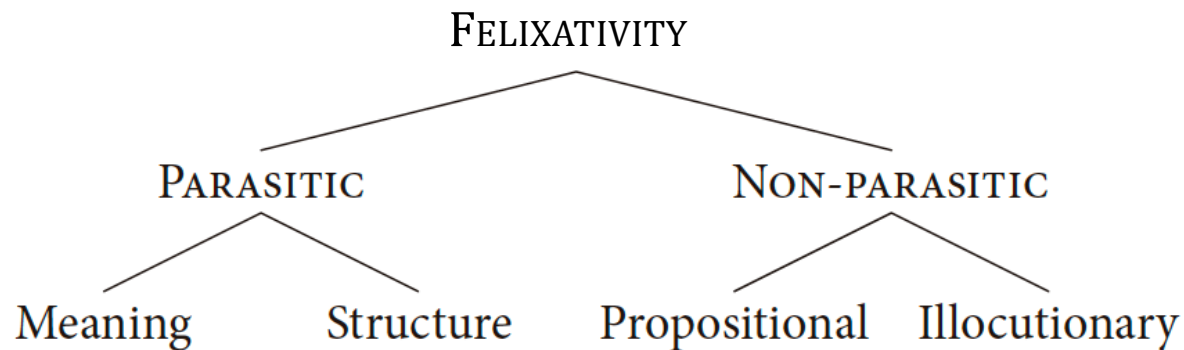
But why?

Peterson 2017

Other logical possibilities

any natural-language expression of **happiness**

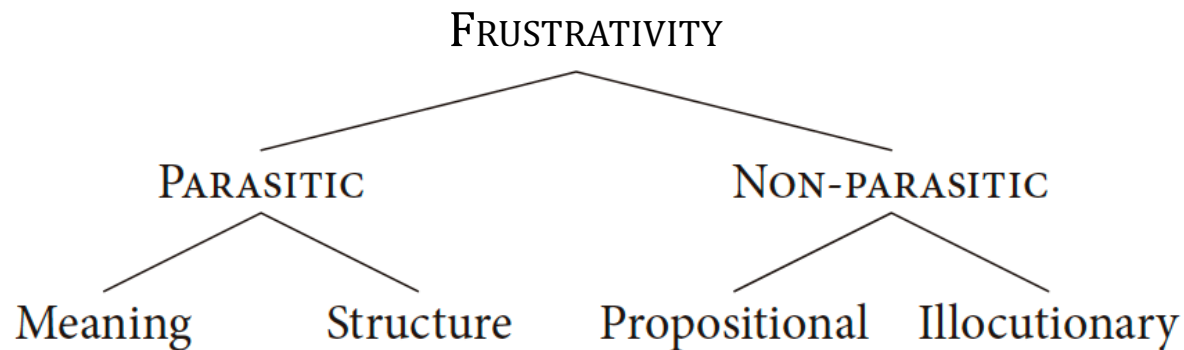
Why not?

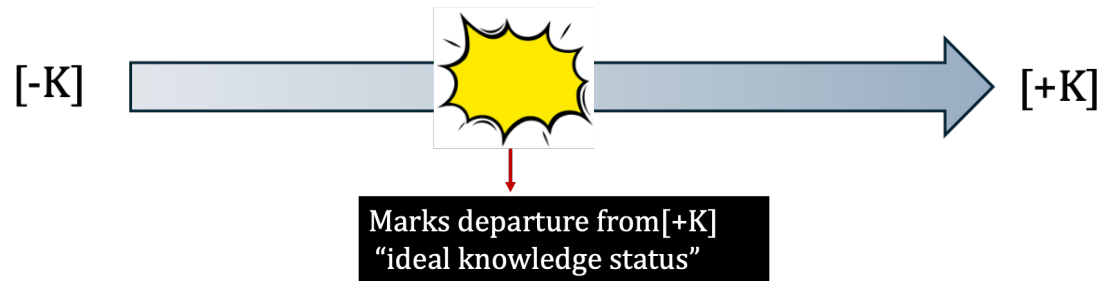


Other logical possibilities

any natural-language expression of **frustration**

Why not?

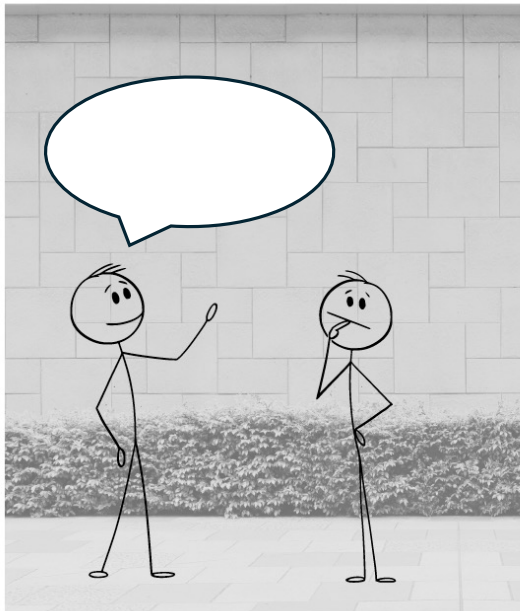




So why ARE miratives expected

Part The view from the grammar of knowledge

Question



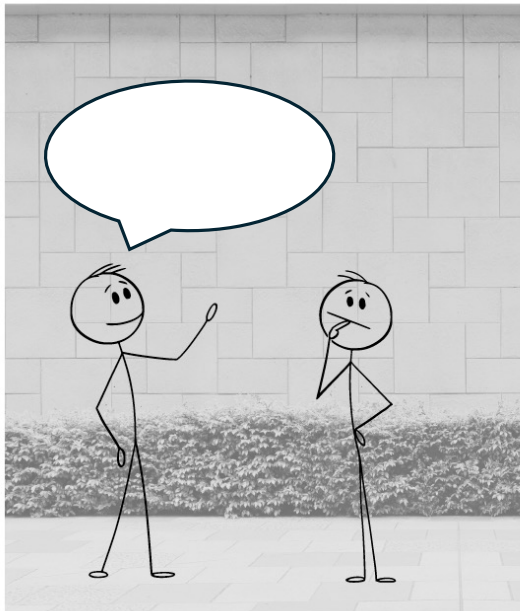
INTERROGATIVE

Wos gib-t's neichs?

What give-3_{SG}=3_{SG.NEUT} new

'What's new?'

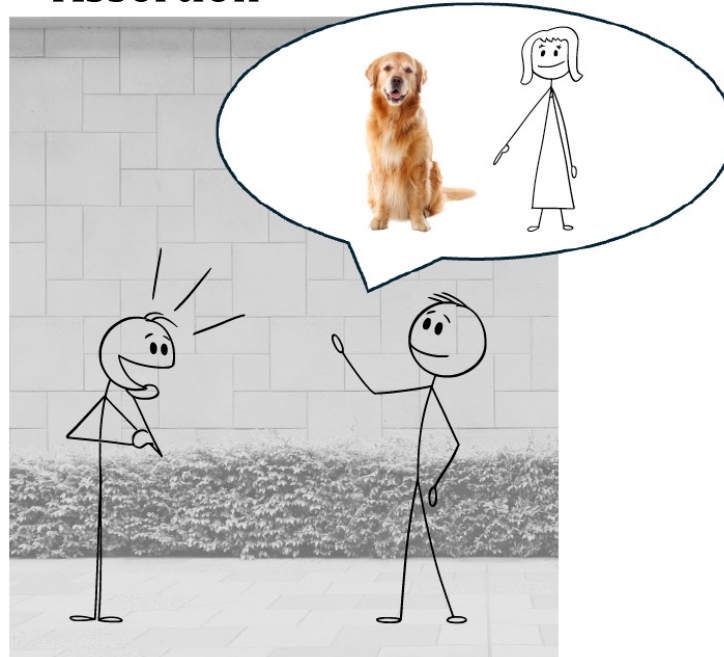
Question



INTERROGATIVE

Was gib-t's neichs?
What give-3SG=3SG.NEUT new
'What's new?'

Assertion



DECLARATIVE

Die Lena hot an Hund
DET Lena has.3SG INDEF dog
'Lena has a dog.'

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

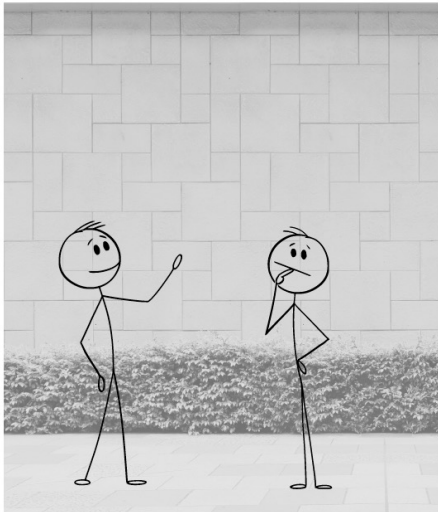
Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

unmarked Speech Act
Clause-type mapping



Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Default contextual assumptions accompanying question acts

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Default contextual assumptions accompanying question acts

S ignorance:

S's epistemic state is neutral relative to the possible resolutions of the issue S raises.

Farkas 2022: 297 (4)

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Default contextual assumptions accompanying question acts

S ignorance:

S's epistemic state is neutral relative to the possible resolutions of the issue S raises.

A competence:

S assumes that A knows the information that settles the issue S raises.

Farkas 2022: 297 (4)

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Norms for Assertions

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Norms for Assertions

Only knowledge warrants assertion.

Williamson (2000: 243)

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Norms for Assertions

Only knowledge warrants assertion.

Williamson (2000: 243)

one ought only to assert what one knows

Stanley (2005: 10)

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

[+K]



DECLARATIVE

Norms for Assertions

Only knowledge warrants assertion. Williamson (2000: 243)

one ought only to assert what one knows Stanley (2005: 10)

[t]he practice of assertion is constituted by the rule/requirement that one assert something only if one knows it. Hawthorne (2004: 23)

Question

[-K]



INTERROGATIVE

Assertion

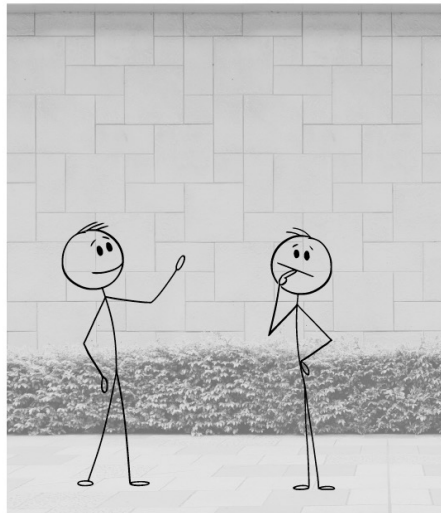
[+K]



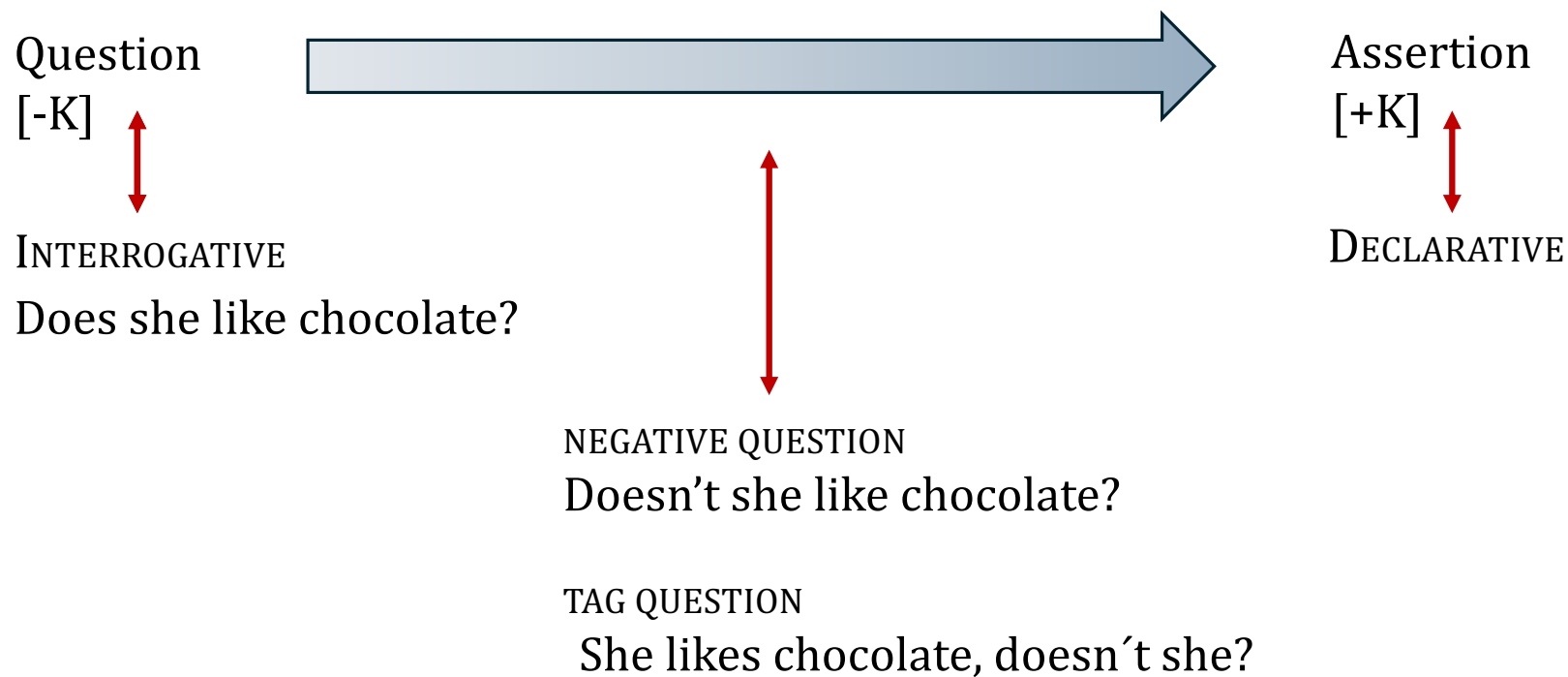
DECLARATIVE

there is more than [+/-K]

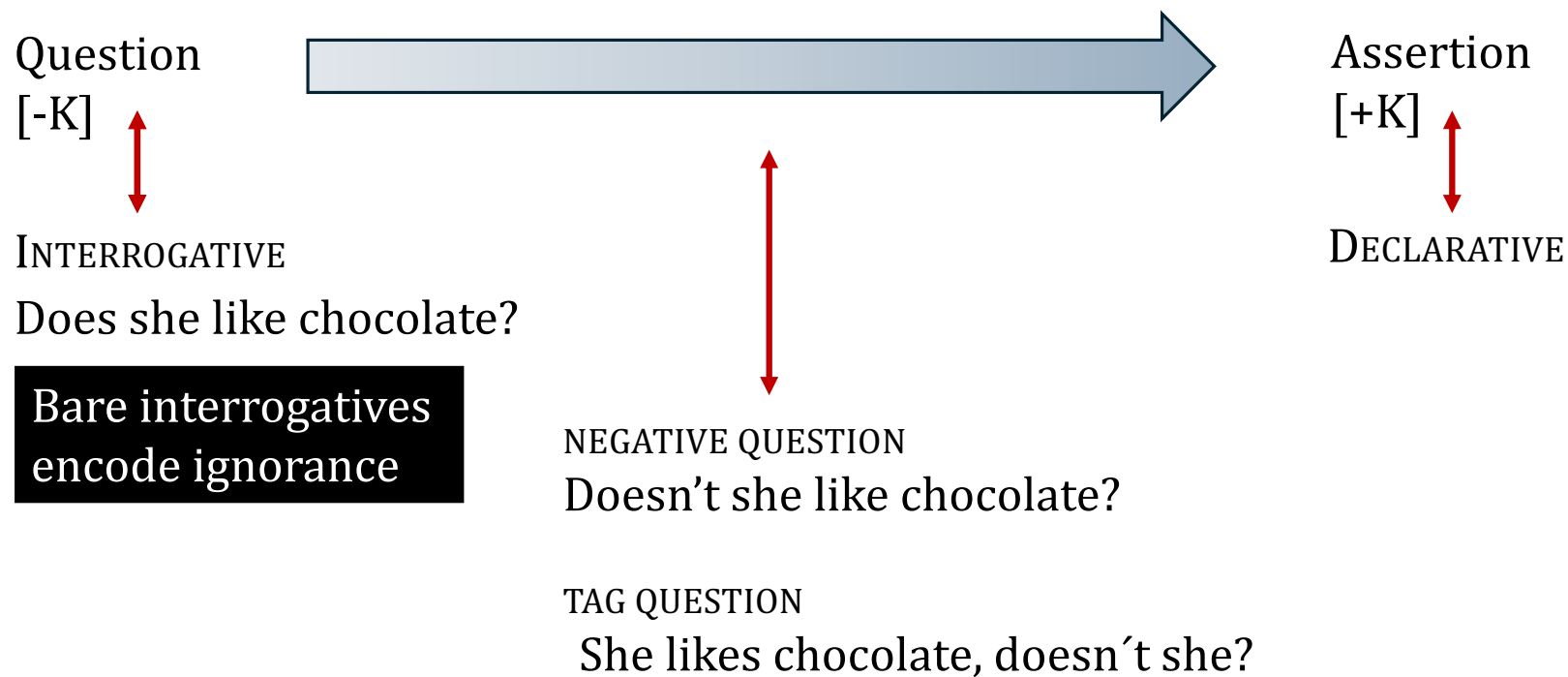
Departure from default
conditions has to be
linguistically marked!



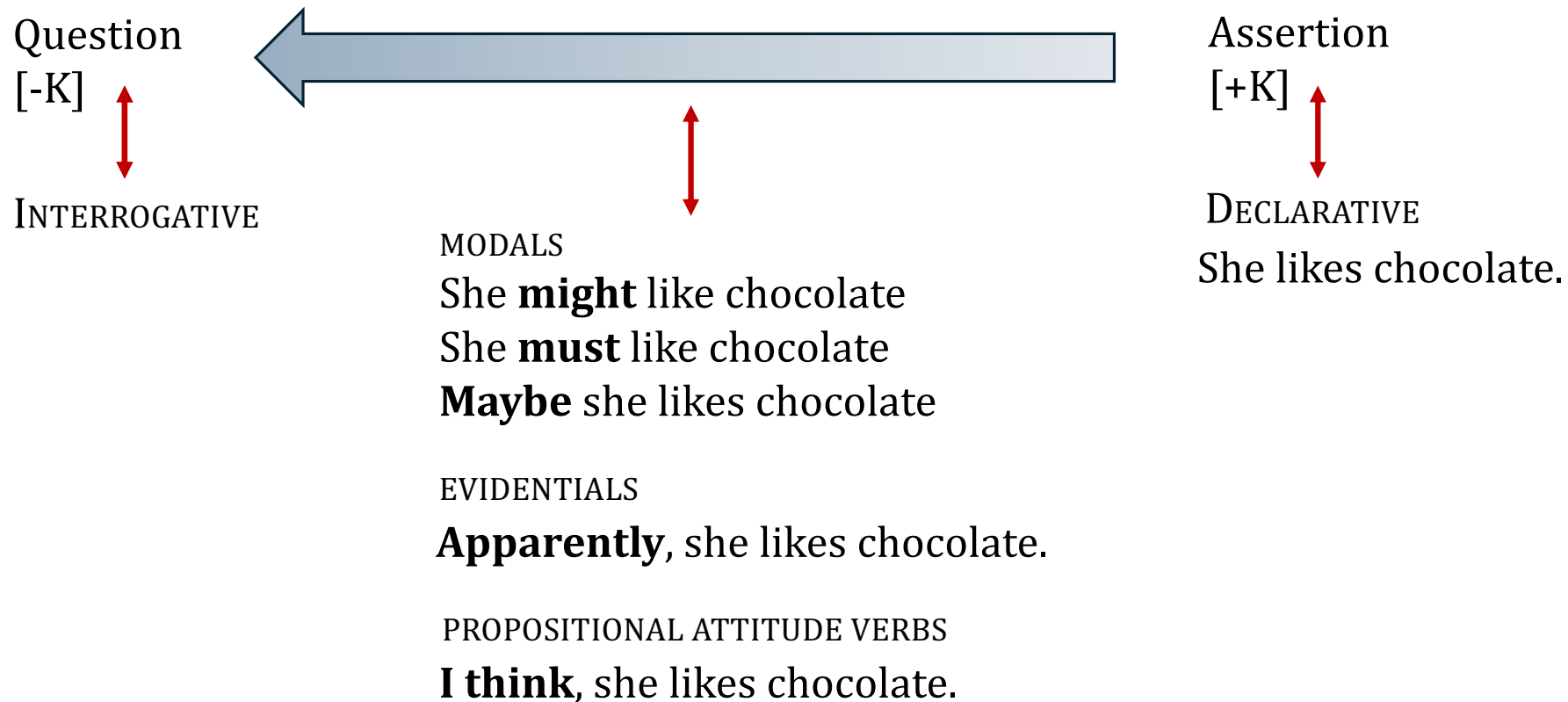
Marking levels of ignorance



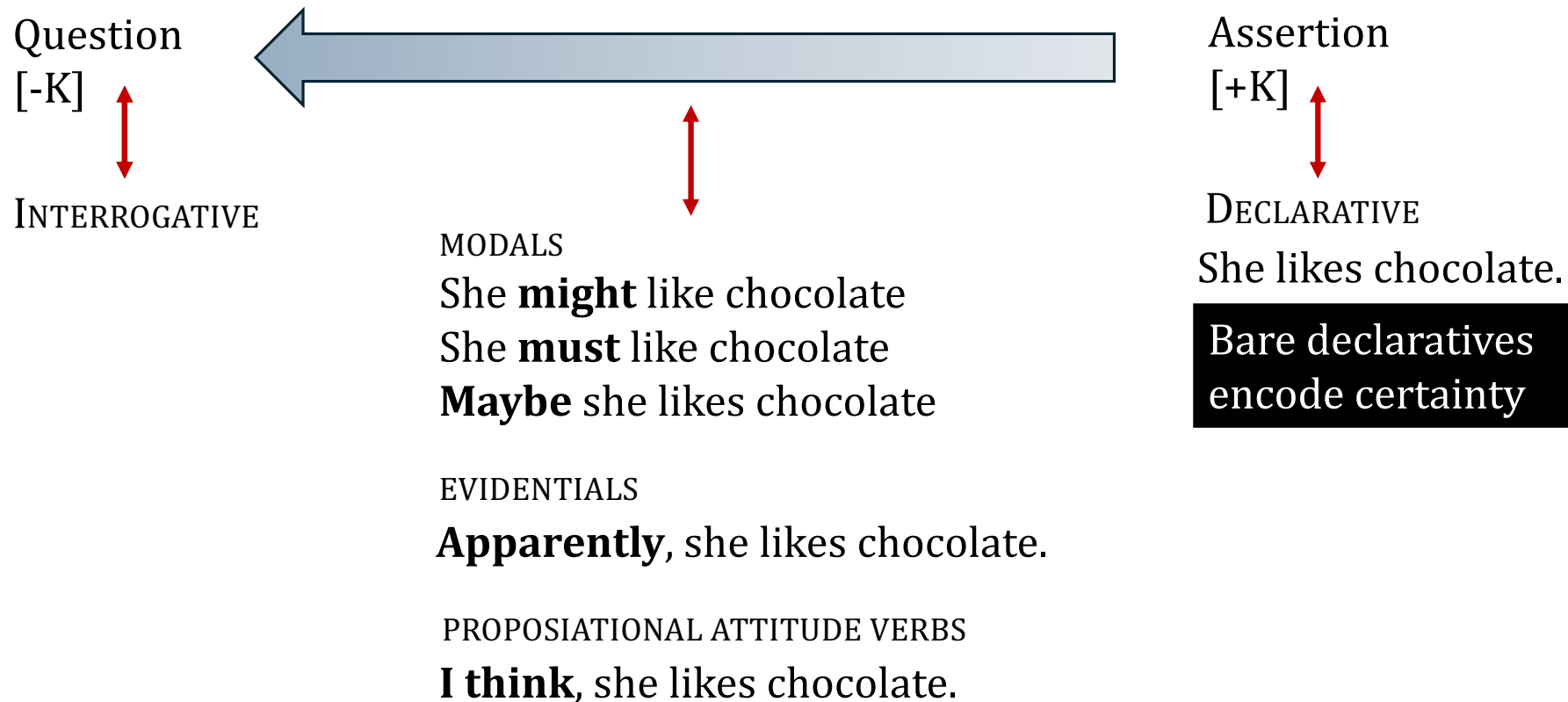
Marking levels of ignorance



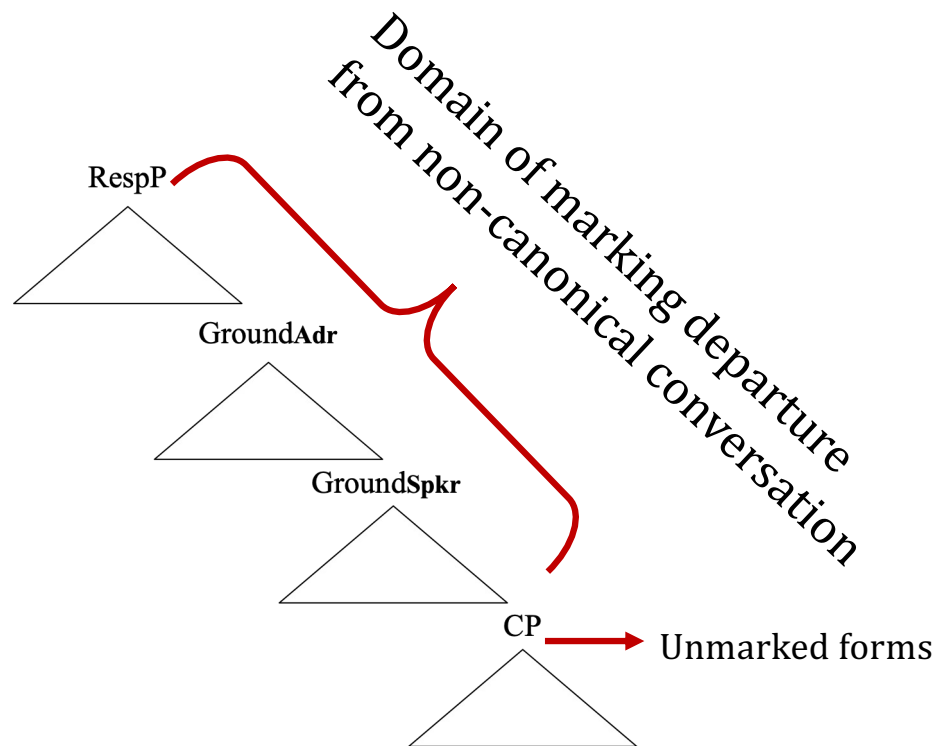
Marking levels of certainty



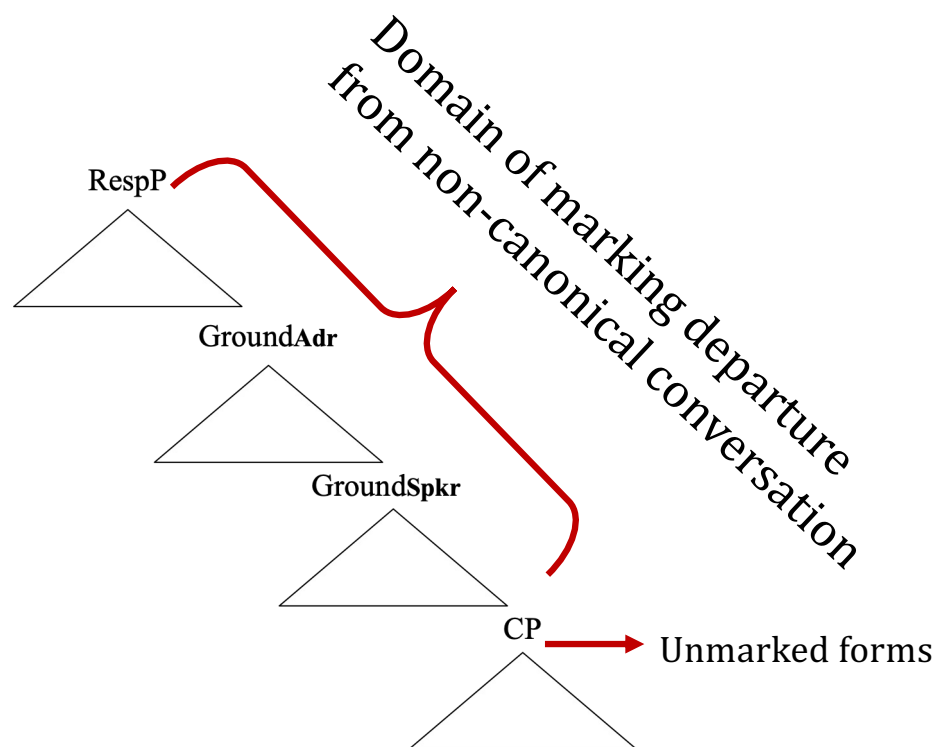
Marking levels of certainty



Miratives and the grammar of knowledge



Miratives and the grammar of knowledge



The grammar of knowledge

Above and Beyond

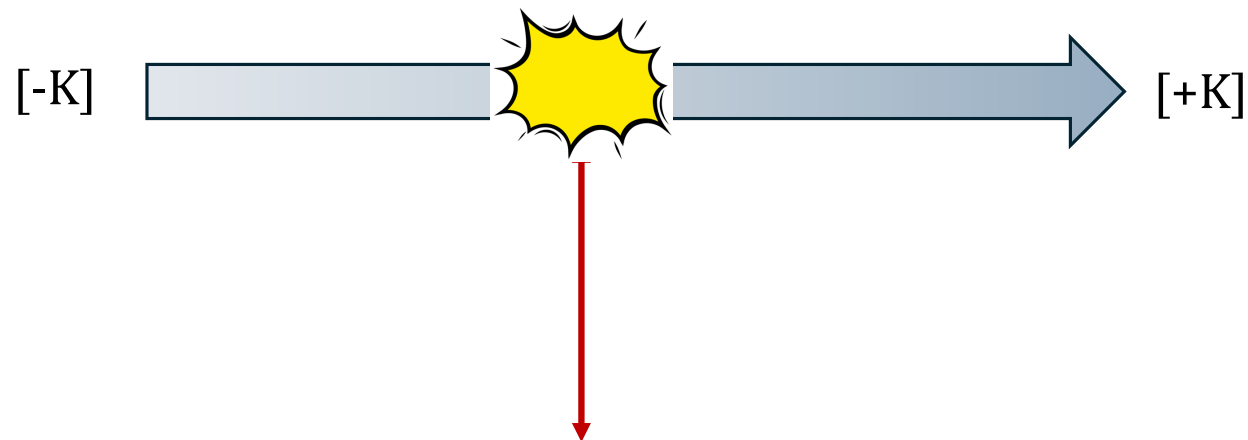
The syntax at the top and how it links to pragmatics

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revised November 2025

to appear in The Oxford Handbook of
Non-Canonical Questions (eds. Eckardt,
Walkden, Dehé)

Marking surprise



MIRATIVE

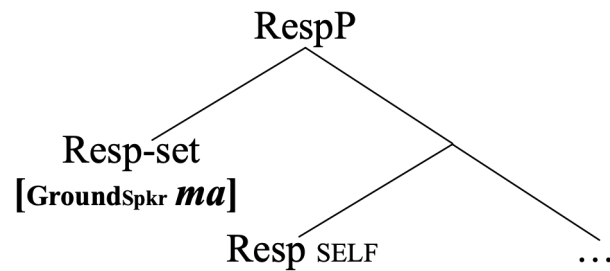
Wow, she likes chocolate!

Marks departure from [+K]
“ideal knowledge status”

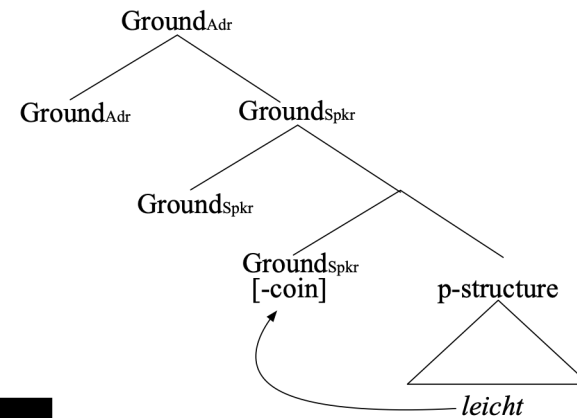
deLancey 2001: 380

Marking surprise

Mirative strategies come about in different ways.

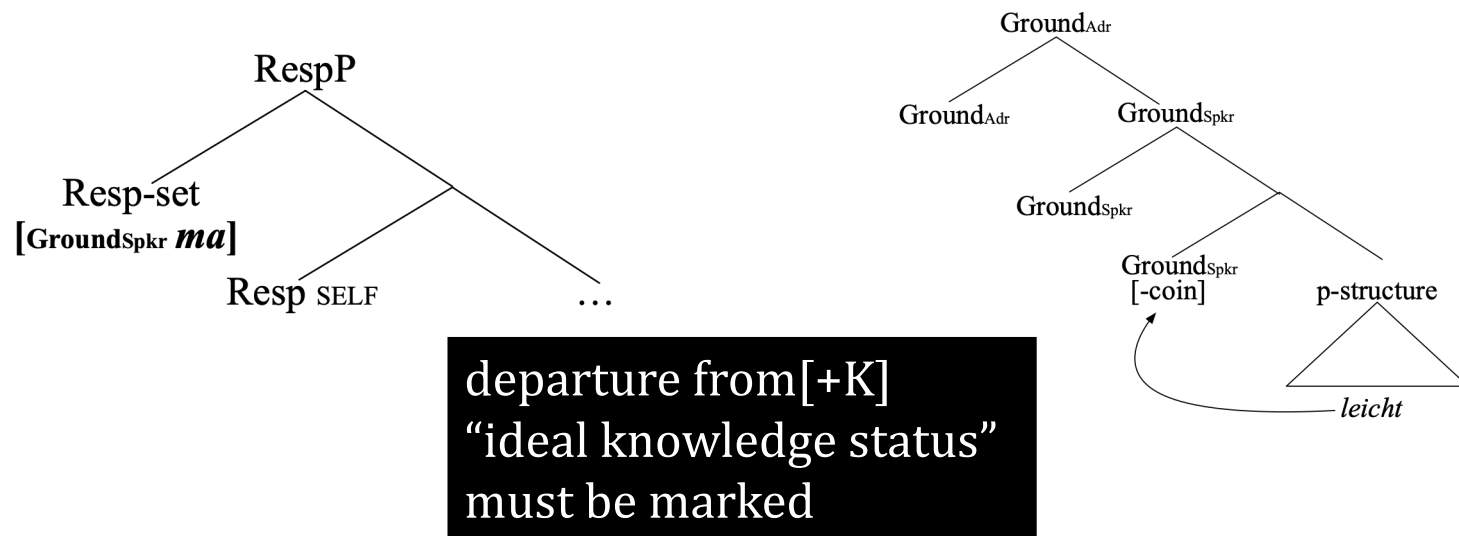


But why?



Marking surprise

Mirative strategies come about in different ways.



Marking surprise

The universalist perspective

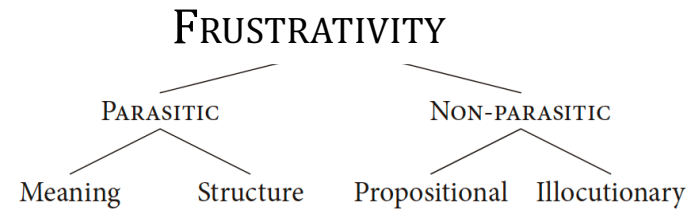
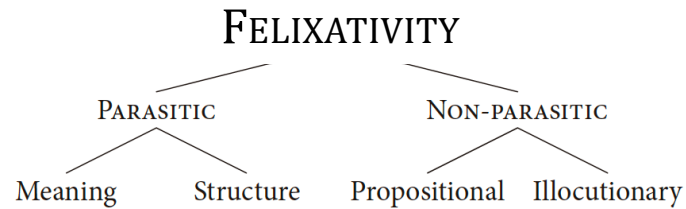
- A (universal) **sememe** (Rett 2021)
- **Not** a (universal) grammatical category (variation in marking)

departure from[+K]
“ideal knowledge status”
must be marked

but there is no dedicated
grammatical category

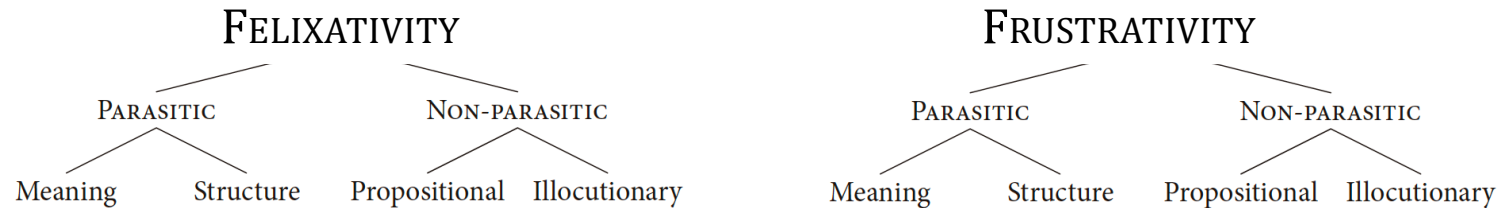
We don't expect grammatical marking of emotions

Why not?



We don't expect grammatical marking of emotions

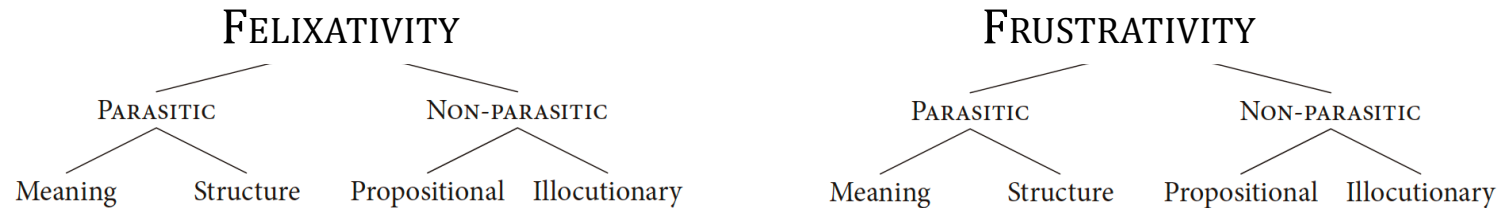
Why not?



there are no linguistically significant assumptions about canonical emotional states

We don't expect grammatical marking of emotions

Why not?

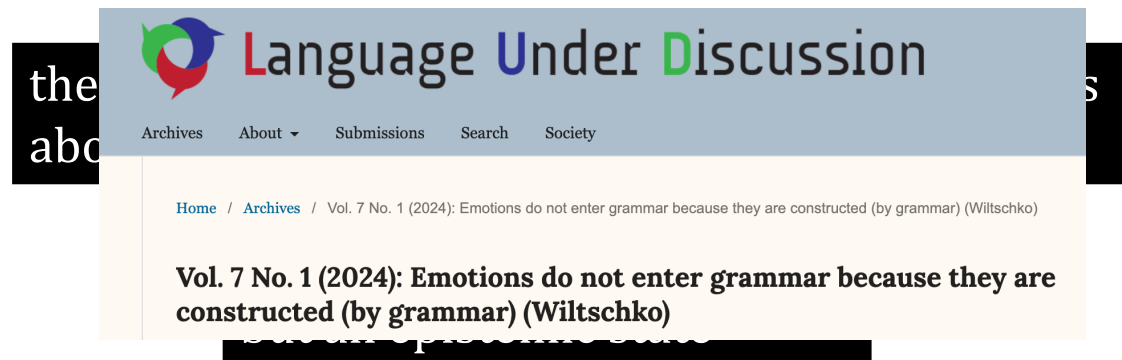
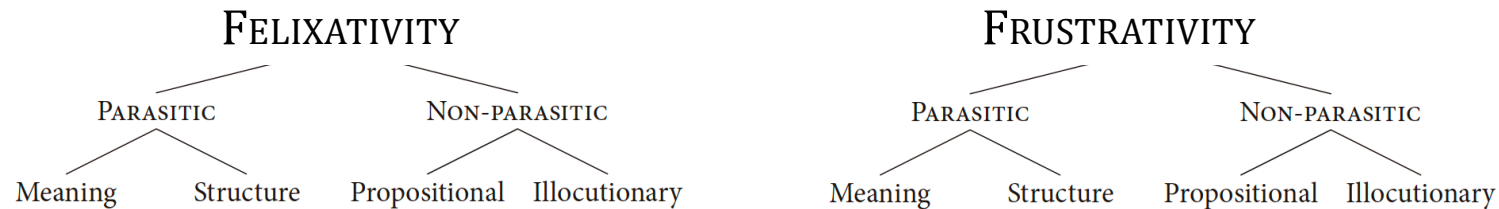


there are no linguistically significant assumptions
about canonical emotional states

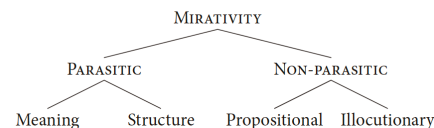
Surprise is NOT an emotion
but an epistemic state

We don't expect grammatical marking of emotions

Why not?



In a nutshell



Why miratives are unexpected

Any natural-language expression of exceeded expectation

2 mirative strategies in Upper Austrian German

Interjections and discourse particles



Why miratives are expected

(Part 1 The view from the **interactional spine**)

interjections:

pro-forms for epistemic states,
used to mark reactions

discourse particles:

mark if p coincides with S/A epistemic state

	Pro Ground _{ep}	Pro Ground _{st}	Ground _{ep} [+coin]	Ground _{st} [+coin]	Ground _{st} [+coin]	Ground _{st} [+coin]
UAG	ma	geh	leicht	huit	owa	
Burgenland	ma	geh	leicht	huit	owa	
Bavarian			leicht	huit	fei	
Swabian	ach				oba	
Norddeutsch	oh	beh				doch
Standard	ach	aber				
	na sowas	aber	etwa		aber	
	wow		echt			
	boah		tatsächlich			
	ey					

Strategies in other German varieties

Why miratives are expected

(Part 2 The view from the **grammar of knowledge**)

bare declaratives are used to express knowledge (assertions)

departure from knowledge **MUST** be linguistically marked

surprise = departure from ideal knowledge status

